

Burden by Design? Proceduralism, Administrative Errors, and the Burden Tolerance of Bureaucrats

Abstract

Administrative errors are a common and understudied source of administrative burdens in public service delivery. However, existing research has yet to consider the impacts of fire alarms over administrative errors on the burden tolerance of bureaucrats. In this article, we leverage theory on proceduralism to understand the unique influence of fire alarms over administrative errors on the burden tolerance of bureaucrats. We conduct a survey experiment of 2,476 bureaucrats working in state agencies in the U.S. to estimate the effects of fire alarms over administrative errors that lead to overpayments or underpayments on the burden tolerance of those bureaucrats. In line with our theory, we find that bureaucrats are more likely to impose additional burdens on potential clients when they experience a fire alarm over an overpayment scandal, whereby potential clients gain access to programs for which they are ineligible. We also find that bureaucrats reduce administrative burdens on potential clients when they experience a fire alarm over an underpayment scandal, where eligible applicants are erroneously denied access. Finally, the magnitude of the effects for the underpayment scenario are significantly smaller than the estimates for the overpayment scenario, revealing the power of fire alarms regarding overpayment for influencing bureaucrats' burden tolerance.

Media attention often reveals administrative errors in government program administration which can lead to further investigation by legislative actors and others (Peeters & Widlak, 2023). For example, the Washington Post recently sued the US government to publish data from the Paycheck Protection Program (PPP). This data suggested that funds appropriated to the program to help maintain payrolls were lent to non-existent companies. In one case, a team of six from East Orange, New Jersey have been accused of attempting to defraud the government via PPP claims using forged tax forms for fake small businesses with at least \$62,000 in overpayments having been disbursed (IRS 2022). In fact, the Small Business Administration itself estimates that at least 70,000 of the PPP loans are potentially fraudulent (Pfeiffer and Fast 2023).

One way to mitigate potential overpayments is by increasing the required documentation from clients in application processes, which would add additional validation and demonstrate a commitment to cracking down on fraud, waste, and abuse. For example, as a result of H.R. 1 (The One Big Beautiful Bill), policymakers are adopting additional work requirements in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) and states will have to grapple with significant new penalties for payment errors (U.S. Food and Nutrition Administration, U.S. Department of Agriculture, 2026). However, these increases in administrative burdens may also lead to underpayments via reducing access to programs for clients, often among those who need the help the most (e.g., Barnes, 2020; Bell et al., 2023; Bell & Jilke, 2024; Chudnovsky & Peeters, 2021; Heinrich et al., 2022; Lasky-Fink & Linos, 2024; Martin et al., 2023; Nisar, 2017). Considering this important tradeoff, we ask: how will bureaucrats use their discretion over administrative burdens when attention is drawn to their programs for improper payments?¹

¹ According to 31 U.S.C. §3351 an improper payment includes the following “any payment that should not have been made or that was made in an incorrect amount, including an overpayment or underpayment, under a statutory, contractual, administrative, or other legally applicable requirement; and... (i) any payment to an ineligible recipient;

Existing explanations predicting whether bureaucrats will decide to shift burdens from the state onto potential clients rely on a theoretical model consisting of characteristics such as political ideology, personality, racial attitudes, or organizational capacity (Aarøe et al., 2021; Bell et al. 2021; Campbell & Ahn, 2023; Dynes et al., 2021; Haeder & Moynihan, 2024; Nicholson-Crotty et al., 2021). Thus, we add that the burden tolerance of bureaucrats is at least partially driven by a previously unexplored factor: fire alarms over administrative errors resulting in improper payments.

In our theoretical model, we integrate administrative burden literature with blame avoidance and reputation management studies to argue that not all fire alarms affect bureaucrats equally. In cases where a fire alarm is raised about administrative errors resulting in *overpayments* to clients (what many think of as fraud, waste, and abuse but includes a much broader set of administrative errors such as clerical mistakes), we argue that bureaucrats will react by shifting significant burdens onto those clients. On the other hand, when a fire alarm raises concerns about administrative errors that result in *underpayments* that provide fewer benefits to eligible applicants than they should receive, we predict that bureaucrats will be less supportive of expanding application burdens. Our work also contributes to existing scholarship by arguing that the magnitude of fire alarms over underpayments to clients will be smaller than the effects in the overpayment frame due to the prevalence and power of fraud as a policy image that poses reputational damage for bureaucrats worried about additional oversight and political control (Carpenter 2010). Moreover, we draw from literature emphasizing bureaucratic proceduralism and negativity bias to justify our prediction that bureaucrats will weigh fire alarms

(ii) any payment for an ineligible good or service; (iii) any duplicate payment; (iv) any payment for a good or service not received, except for those payments where authorized by law; and (v) any payment that does not account for credit for applicable discounts.”

on overpayments more heavily than fire alarms calling attention to underpayments (Bagley, 2019; James et al., 2020; Moynihan, 2025).

We evaluate our expectations through a pre-registered experiment embedded in a survey of 2,476 bureaucrats working in U.S. state agencies across 9 states. Our results indicate that concerns about overpayments increase support for increasing the application requirements associated with a stylized small business development program, while concerns about underpayments associated with the inability of qualified applicants to access the same program prompt lower levels of support for increasing those burdens. Further, our results also demonstrate that the magnitudes of the effects related to overpayments are significantly larger than those related to underpayments. Additionally, our analyses show that bureaucrats are not uniformly supportive of all kinds of administrative burdens, but instead demonstrate substantial variation in their levels of support for different kinds of application requirements; for instance, while respondents in all conditions express strong support for increasing income verification requirements, respondents are generally opposed to or neutral on raising the minimum credit rating applicants must have. These findings have significant implications for burden reduction initiatives across the US and elsewhere, demonstrating the importance of fire alarms about administrative errors and the importance of specific burden types over others.

These findings have important theoretical and practical implications. First, we integrate literature on blame avoidance and reputation management with administrative burden literature, showing that bureaucrats perceive management of administrative burdens as a tool for responding to negative media coverage. As such, our study is among the first to demonstrate that adoption of administrative burdens is a tool for blame avoidance for bureaucrats. Second, our findings demonstrate the importance of a previously underexplored factor in predicting the

burden tolerance of bureaucrats: administrative errors in the form of improper payments. Third, our study demonstrates that in many cases administrative burdens may originate because of mistakes made by the bureaucracy in the past or fear of making those mistakes in the future. Finally, our results add significant nuance to burden tolerance studies by revealing that not all application burdens are viewed equally.

The Determinants of Burden Tolerance

Administrative burdens are generated and experienced by both citizens and street-level bureaucrats in citizen-state interactions (Burden et al., 2012; Ferraioli, 2025; Stanica et al., 2022; Yu, 2024). Heinrich (2016) offers a useful framework based on bureaucratic encounter theory that illustrates the different types of encounters where administrative burdens may arise. First, administrative burdens may be the result of intra-organizational encounters (cell 1), in which agency leadership and SLBs face political and organizational pressure that shape how implementation decisions are made. Second, administrative burdens may arise in bureaucratic encounters initiated by citizens seeking public services (cell 2) and/or encounters with citizens initiated by bureaucrats (cell 3). Importantly, this framework recognizes that administrative burden is not exclusively a tool wielded against citizens. Instead, SLBs themselves can experience burden and can even take on the burdens facing citizens by moving toward clients or moving with clients and offering personal resources to aid citizens in accessing public services (Bell & Smith, 2022; Burden et al., 2012; Edri-Peer & Cohen, 2025; Ferraioli, 2025; Stanica et al., 2022; Tummers et al., 2015; Yu, 2024).

Most administrative burden scholarship has focused on the consequences of burdens in cell 2 and cell 3, where citizens are interacting directly with bureaucrats. This research demonstrates the negative consequences of administrative burdens (i.e., learning, compliance,

and psychological costs in citizen-state interactions) for clients' access to public services, mental health, and emotional well-being (e.g., Baekgaard et al., 2022; Bækgaard et al., 2024; Bell et al., 2023; Haeder & Moynihan, 2023; Hattke et al., 2020; Herd & Moynihan, 2020, 2018; Linos et al., 2020; Peeters, 2019). While there is ample research investigating the consequences of administrative burdens in encounters where citizens are seeking access to public services, less research has investigated the causes and origins of administrative burden adoption by bureaucrats and the intraorganizational dynamics (cell 1) such as the political and organizational pressures that flow from agency leadership to SLBs to shape the conditions under which implementation decisions are made (Halling & Baekgaard, 2023). Recent scholarly work suggests that administrative burdens can be driven by individual bureaucrats and the discretion they have in policy implementation; in other words, no matter the policy design that legislators put in place, individual bureaucrats have the power to reduce or intensify clients' experiences of administrative burdens (Bell & Jilke, 2024; Bell & Smith, 2022; Benish et al., 2024; Herd & Moynihan, 2018; Jilke et al., 2018).

Existing explanations for why policymakers and bureaucrats support the expansion of administrative burdens have focused on personality, personal experience, political ideology, and racial attitudes (Aarøe et al., 2021; Baekgaard et al., 2020; Bækgaard et al., 2024; Bell et al., 2021; Bell & Meyer, 2023; Bell & Smith, 2022; Campbell & Ahn, 2023; Haeder & Moynihan, 2023; Heinrich et al., 2022; Newswander et al., 2024; Peeters, 2019). However, in some cases, burdens may be adopted because limited administrative capacity and high workloads (Andersen & Guul, 2019; Bell & Meyer, 2023; Guul et al., 2019) or reduced because policymakers have personal experience with burdensome programs (Baekgaard et al., 2020). Importantly, burdens originating from limited administrative capacity and high workload may be distinct from “hidden

politics” and may originate from unintentional practices that are the result of internal organizational dynamics rather than bureaucrats using discretion to accomplish political goals (Peeters, 2019).

We center these contextual explanations for changes in administrative burden, arguing that the environment, one that emphasizes proceduralism, reduces the importance and effect of ideology found in previous research. This is, in fact, in line with earlier research on poll workers in New Mexico (Atkeson et al. 2014b). Atkeson and colleagues find that the context of being a poll worker and specific associated beliefs, not partisanship, explain street-level bureaucrat use of discretion and inconsistent application of voter ID laws. Thus, we argue that the context in which bureaucrats operate matters; the culture of proceduralism and the rule bound nature of bureaucratic structures create a unique decision environment in which bureaucrats are not always using burdens to advance policy goals, but instead may be taking actions to avoid additional oversight from political leaders and reputational damage and/or scrutiny inflicted by fire alarms (Damonte et al., 2014; Durant, 1991; McCubbins & Schwartz, 1984).

Together, we argue that burden tolerance studies have yet to empirically test a factor that many bureaucrats face in the administration of programs: administrative errors resulting in improper payments, which can prompt criticism from political principals and the public, damage agency reputations, and hurt agency morale. This factor helps answer a question posed by early administrative burden work, “under what conditions do ‘hidden politics’ become visible” (Moynihan, Herd, and Harvey 2014, pg. 63). Foundational work on administrative burden theorized about the importance of administrative errors, fraud, and overpayments (Herd & Moynihan, 2018), but empirical tests with bureaucrats have been limited in existing literature. In

this way, we highlight a novel factor that reflects the unique political and organizational context bureaucrats operate within to theorize about the drivers of burden tolerance.

Administrative Errors, and the Burden Tolerance of Bureaucrats

Prominent research has focused on the adoption of administrative burden as “hidden politics” whereby burdens are imposed on the public to accomplish political goals such as reducing the cost of programs, without necessitating the legislature to publicly reduce funding for popular programs (Herd & Moynihan, 2018; Moynihan & Herd, 2023). However, scholars have also recognized that unintentional or intentional organizational practices that cause administrative errors are another source of administrative burden, especially in more complex programs (Bullock, 2014; Holler et al., 2024; Peeters, 2019; Widlak & Peeters, 2020).

Administrative errors can result in overpayments or underpayments, and many governments have attempted to reduce the instance of improper payments globally (Greer & Bullock, 2018; Morton-Huddleston et al., 2018)². When administrative errors occur, oftentimes political officials in the legislature and even political principals within the executive branch must contend with negative media attention, reputational damage, and increased political oversight (Compton et al., 2023; Damonte et al., 2014; Maor & Sulitzeanu-Kenan, 2016; Young et al., 2023).

Bureaucrats dedicated to the mission and success of the programs they administer may take action to demonstrate to political officials that they take the stewardship of taxpayer dollars seriously. When concerns about over- or underpayments arise that undermine that bureaucratic commitment, bureaucrats can try to assuage stakeholders by increasing or decreasing

² Common measures of error rates often also include procedural mistakes and paperwork errors, such as unsigned or missing forms, that occur even when the payment level is correct and paid to the correct individual, as Herd (“The Big Beautiful Bill has a SNAP Poison Pill”, <https://substack.com/home/post/p-174988121>) notes. Thus, the measurement of improper payments includes much more than what people might commonly understand as administrative errors, including simple paperwork failures.

administrative burdens, respectively, that may reduce the prevalence of those errors. Thus, when bureaucrats are primed to think about program overpayments, such as fraud, we expect that they will respond by raising the administrative burdens potential clients must satisfy to access the program.

Hypothesis 1: *When concerns about overpayments arise, bureaucrats are more supportive of expanding application requirements.*

In contrast, when bureaucrats are made to consider program underpayments, such as denying eligible individuals access to programs, we expect that bureaucrats will respond by lowering the burdens potential clients face when trying to use the program.

Hypothesis 2: *When a program attracts attention for underpayment (poor accessibility), bureaucrats are less supportive of expanding application requirements.*

In both Hypothesis 1 and 2, we depart from prior studies by theorizing that the prospect or realization of administrative errors motivates bureaucrats to alter levels of administrative burden to anticipate or appear responsive to those errors, regardless of those bureaucrats' underlying characteristics such as political ideology, personality, or racial attitudes. At the agency level, leadership may partake in morale, reputation, and/or political oversight management. Following a media report of administrative errors, agency leaders face a variety of potential incentives and pathways forward.

First, leaders may engage in reputation management. Managers that choose this path will focus on external dynamics, with a particular emphasis on public and media relations. This response could improve bureaucratic reputation as recent evidence suggests that the public, at least in Denmark, prefer fewer documentation requirements, or compliance burdens, regardless

of program integrity (Stenderup & Pedersen, 2025). In fact, the evidence from this study suggests that the public may prefer reduced documentation requirements under both under- and overpayment scenarios. Thus, reputation management may lead to reduced application requirements, and burdens, regardless of the type of administrative error.

On the other hand, managers may engage in political oversight management. For overpayments, we would expect similar dynamics. That is, agency managers seeking to reduce political oversight after an overpayment ‘scandal’ may encourage SLBs to process requests more slowly and deliberately. On the other hand, underpayment scandals may have relatively limited effects on manager behaviors given political oversight in this context would be minimal. To this end, we attempt to map out a theoretical model of our experiment and expectations in Figure 1. We have shaded in the agency leadership response as in our design we do not measure or investigate these factors, instead we focus on the downstream realization of these effects on street-level bureaucrat behaviors.

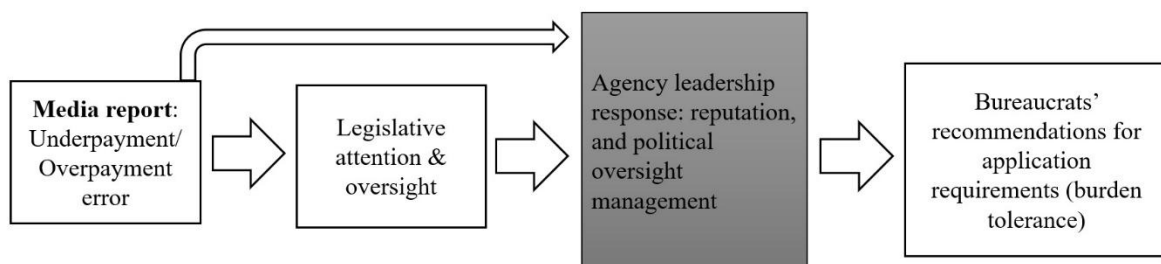


Figure 1: Theoretical Model of Media and Political Attention on Bureaucratic Behavior

Thus, bureaucrat implementation of additional, or fewer, burdens may be used to reduce the scrutiny from politicians and the media to reduce damage to organizational image, especially if the change in burdensome application requirements reduces the chances of future overpayments or underpayments. In fact, recent descriptive research on federal bureaucrats in Mexico, a context similar to the US regarding burdensome policies, suggest this may be the case (Erllich et al. 2021; Baekgaard, Martin, and Petersen 2025). Erllich and co-authors used detailed administrative data merged with extensive media coverage to find that bureaucrats responded more quickly, that is reduced burden, to information requests when the media was reporting about government failure but were slower to respond, increased burden, when the media was reporting about corruption. These patterns suggest lower-level bureaucrats actively engage in strategic reputation management via the implementation of administrative burdens. Similarly, experimental evidence in the EU also suggests bureaucrats may be more responsive to requests when media attention is negative as opposed to non-existent (Rimkutė and van der Voet 2024).

Finally, we argue that overpayments will prompt bureaucrats to make more dramatic reforms than will underpayments because the culture, ethics, and proceduralism of administrative agencies prompt them to weigh the implications of these two types of improper payments differently (Bagley, 2019; Moynihan, 2025). First, we highlight the culture and ethics of administrative agencies to justify our prediction. Being good stewards of taxpayer funds is a *foundational ethos* among government employees and bureaucrats, who often face political pressure from elected officials and the media to improve the integrity of programs, be better stewards of tax-payer funds, and ensure that eligibility criteria are not being circumvented by applicants (Bell and Smith 2022; Atkeson et al 2014b).

From an operational standpoint, this cultural and ethical obligation is formalized in administrative procedures (Krause and Hong 2024). For instance, every budget cycle bureaucrats must justify the funding they receive for programs administered by their agency, and part of this process involves audits of payments made to applicants. In this process, it is usually easier to disburse funds that should have been paid than to ‘claw back’ funds inappropriately disbursed. In addition to the pressure bureaucrats face to address overpayments in their day-to-day operations, culture, and ethics, bureaucrats also must contend with political optics and there are few worse political firestorms than a fraud scandal for an agency or program’s reputational image (Carpenter & Krause, 2012). In fact, for certain programs, investigations for overpayments are legally required, while investigations for underpayments are not, effectively institutionalizing and enculturating a certain form of loss aversion (Kahneman and Tversky 1992; Krause and Hong 2024). These institutionalized procedures suggest that bureaucrats will behave preemptively to reduce overpayment given the institutional and legal evidence that their political principals, legislative and executive, are more concerned about excessive spending or waste than program access. As Herd & Moynihan (2018) argue “As far back as the Nixon administration, welfare programs have not been designed to balance take-up by eligible claimants with mistaken payments to ineligible beneficiaries; instead, administrative procedures have been used to reduce the former in the name of the latter. Federal quality control guidelines offered states stronger incentives to avoid overpayment rather than to enroll eligible participants. Contemporary performance evaluations of welfare programs maintain this tradition by rewarding reductions in fraud measures but neglecting beneficiary take-up” (p. 34).

More broadly, research on welfare policy and media coverage has revealed that popular images of fraudsters are pervasive and often convey racialized and gendered messages that

invoke underlying biases that can reduce public and policymakers' support for programs that bureaucrats are administering (e.g., Baekgaard et al., 2022; Gilens, 2009). Most importantly for our work, this image centers the specific fraud of one case as a much more extensive and generalized phenomenon. Therefore, overpayments to applicants for government programs are likely to be a particularly sensitive subject among bureaucrats and will likely elicit a stronger response than what we observe among bureaucrats under fire for underpayments.

When it comes to concerns about underpayments restricting access to public services, we argue that bureaucrats will be less responsive. From an institutional perspective, this is driven in part by the onus of correcting the error being put onto the client to communicate the error to the bureaucrat and system, and the lack of automation of corrections (Widlak and Peeters 2020; Holler, Tarshish, and Kaplan 2023). While from an individual perspective, previous research has demonstrated the negativity bias that leads to blame avoidance and even overcompliance due to extreme caution among bureaucrats of violating statutes or procedures (such as those in the Administrative Procedures Act) (James et al., 2020). This leads to what many term “proceduralism” which Moynihan (2025) defines as “the tendency of public sector systems, and the people operating within them, to focus on rules, constraints, and processes to the point that they severely degrade their own capacity to perform the primary goals the public has assigned them” (p. 4). Over time, proceduralism leads to the accumulation of formal processes, paperwork, and rules that create red tape for bureaucrats and administrative burdens for clients.

However, in an underpayment scenario where those burdens have caused eligible individuals to lose access to public benefits, bureaucrats can blame several other culprits. For example, bureaucrats can manipulate the attribution of blame away from themselves and onto either the applicants or policymakers for benefits that were not distributed to eligible applicants

(Holler, Tarshish, and Kaplan 2023). Additionally, extensive paperwork and burdensome requirements are generally the status quo for bureaucrats administering programs with complex legal and reporting requirements due to proceduralism, which may lead bureaucrats to fail to see documentation requirements as a burden on the public and instead as a necessary evil for acquiring funding to support their programs (Bagley 2019). Therefore, while concerns about overpayment errors may increase support for increasing documentation and compliance costs, concerns about underpayment errors may not increase support for reducing documentation as intensely.³

While research suggests reductions in burden do in fact increase program take-up (Fox, Stazyk and Feng 2020; Bell, Kappes and Williams 2024), the compound effects of proceduralism and institutionalized penalties for wasteful spending will likely dampen the burden reduction effects of access concerns. In combination with these institutional dynamics is the tendency of humans to weight losses more than equivalent gains as identified by prospect theory (Kahneman and Tversky 1992). Previous research has documented cases of bureaucrats adopting algorithms to identify fraud which ultimately resulted in costly scandals (Peeters & Widlak, 2023; Priergaard, 2024). In the case of Robodebt, this scandal ended up costing the government money rather than achieving the intended cost savings due to the lawsuits from members of the public who were adversely impacted (Henriques-Gomes, 2023; Priergaard, 2024). These cases reflect what Holler, Tarshish and Kaplan (2023) identify as efforts to reduce Type 1 error (false positives or fraud) that inadvertently also increased Type 2 errors (false negatives or reducing access).

³ For example, bureaucrats may prefer to invest in navigators or other third-party assistance to help applicants rather than changing the required documents, which may involve additional legal hurdles.

Together, we argue that these dynamics will lead bureaucrats to weigh the risk of overpayment more heavily than the risk of denying eligible applicants program access.

***Hypothesis 3:** The effect of overpayment on support for burdens is of larger magnitude than the effect of underpayment on support for burdens.*

Research Design

Examining the effect of administrative errors on bureaucrats' preferences for administrative burden poses important inferential challenges. First, it is difficult to determine how bureaucrats weigh the potential for different types of administrative errors when they make decisions about how to implement government programs. Second, even if the array of forces that influence the level of burden bureaucrats implement for policies was fully observable, we would not be able to isolate the effect administrative errors from other factors related to both administrative errors and the level of burden. In light of these barriers to both observing the data needed to assess the relationship between administrative errors and burden tolerance and isolating that relationship from other potential confounders, we conducted a pre-registered survey experiment with state-level bureaucrats in 9 US states that randomly assigned respondents to vignettes that present scenarios where administrative errors result in either concerns about overpayments or underpayments, respectively, before asking them to indicate their preferred level of administrative burdens for a hypothetical policy program. In utilizing an experimental design, we can observe the behavior of real-world bureaucrats who have experience with setting

and implementing administrative burdens as we systematically alter the presence and type of improper payments in isolation from other potential confounders.⁴

Protocol

We included our pre-registered experiment in a survey of state-level bureaucrats fielded between May 31 and June 26, 2024.⁵ The sampling frame for the survey included all state government employees whose email addresses were publicly available through the states' online directories in the following nine states: Connecticut, Florida, Illinois, Indiana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, North Carolina, Oregon, and Vermont. The bureaucratic institutions of these states and the people who work in them may not be wholly representative of state-level agencies across the United States, but they were chosen to ensure variation on important, socioeconomic, political, and cultural dimensions that may influence the preferences and behaviors of bureaucrats such as state size and geographic location, party control of the states' governorship and legislature, and the distribution of racial and ethnic groups in the population.⁶ 2,476 of the

⁴ While nearly all bureaucrats encounter administrative burdens in at least some aspects of their jobs, bureaucrats in certain kinds of positions may have more experience with designing and implementing burdens than others. To assess this possibility, we drew on respondents' pre-treatment answers to questions about how frequently they engaged in "policymaking" and "implementation" tasks in the course of their jobs, as well as how often they "interact directly with members of the public," and repeated out analyses on the subsamples of respondents who reported "very" and "somewhat" frequently engaging in each of those activities and those who reported "not very frequently" or "never" engaging in each of those activities. The results of these subsample analyses, presented in Tables S9-S14, are substantively consistent with those conducted with the full sample, suggesting that the degree of first-hand experience the bureaucrats had with policymaking and implementation tasks that often involve burdens did not condition their responses to our treatments.

⁵ Our pre-analysis plan is available through the Open Science Framework: https://osf.io/epb2g?view_only=b356267aecfe4a4983f6c9721113e818.

⁶ Please see Supplemental Information Section B, specifically Tables S1-S4, for more information on the selection of states, collection of state bureaucrat email addresses, and descriptive statistics of respondents across experiment conditions

219,103 individuals who received invitations to participate in the survey completed the module containing this experiment, yielding a response rate of 1.1% (2,476/219,103).⁷

After completing a battery of pre-treatment questions, we asked respondents to imagine working at the department of commerce in a state different than their own and provided them with a short vignette about a Small Business Development Program (SBDP) the department is responsible for administering. Respondents read that SBDP is a loan guarantee program that helps small businesses secure loans from local financial institutions. Through loan guarantee programs, which are commonly administered at the federal, state, and local level in the United States, government agencies help individuals or organizations acquire loans from private financial institutions by guaranteeing to compensate the institutions for some or all of the loan amounts in the case of default; consequently, loan applicants who may not be able to secure private loans on their own are better able to access financing. We choose to study the effects of administrative errors in the context of small businesses because many prior studies focus entirely on welfare programs. Small business development programs are potentially less politicized and less associated with deservingness than social welfare. Further, small business development

⁷ Our response rate is lower than those obtained in other recently published survey experiments using American elite samples (Furnas and LaPira 2024; Miller 2022), but it is similar to response rates for surveys of the American mass public (e.g., “You Ask, We Answer: How the Times/Siena Poll is Conducted,” The New York Times, October 22, 2024, <https://www.nytimes.com/article/times-siena-poll-methodology.html>) and the size of our sampling frame ensured we would obtain enough respondents to facilitate well-powered analyses. We believe our relatively low response rate is a product of state government employees having been trained by information technology professionals to be skeptical of emails from unfamiliar senders; we discuss some of the evidence behind this belief in Supplemental Information A. We also discuss concerns about generalizability in Supplemental Information B, comparing the demographics characteristics of our respondents with those of the full population government employees working for the states included in the sample. These comparisons show substantial similarities, though we have somewhat higher proportions of white respondents and our respondents tend to be older, have more state government experience, and have higher levels of educational attainment.

programs are common across the US at all levels of government and therefore likely to be familiar, in some respect, to most respondents.⁸

In the vignette, respondents are told that the SBDP is undergoing an audit, and their supervisor has asked them to make recommendations to modify its system for verifying businesses' eligibility for SBDP. Our main experimental manipulation is the rationale provided for the SBDP audit in our vignette, through which we alter respondents' exposure to either overpayments or underpayments.⁹ In the control condition, respondents read that SBDP must be reauthorized early next year and that state legislators have requested an audit ahead of that reauthorization; this language is intended to convey to respondents that the audit is a routine part of the program's lifecycle and not prime administrative error considerations.¹⁰ In our fraud condition, we tell respondents that a local news station recently ran investigative reports revealing that 20% of the loans subsidized by SBDP were given to businesses who were

⁸ For instance, all nine states in our sample administer small business loan guarantee programs funded by the US Department of Treasury's State Small Business Credit Initiative, collectively providing \$1.53 billion of guaranteed financing to small businesses in their states ("Capital Program Summaries." *US Department of the Treasury*, <https://home.treasury.gov/policy-issues/small-business-programs/state-small-business-credit-initiative-ssbci/capital-program-summaries>). Though funding for these loans was provided by the federal government, each state needed to design its own program, including the eligibility requirements for prospective applicants. Importantly, while our vignette focuses on a loan guarantee program for small businesses, governments commonly offer similar programs to finance activities undertaken by other people or entities, such as personal mortgages, student loans, and those implementing innovative energy technologies ("Public-Private Risk Sharing in Federal Credit Programs." *Congressional Budget Office*, September 2024, <https://www.cbo.gov/publication/60713>). Thus, many state-level bureaucrats who do not directly work with small businesses should nonetheless have familiarity with administering loan guarantee programs and therefore have relevant experience from which to draw when participating in the experiment. To verify this, we examined the state website for each agency that at least one of our respondents worked to determine whether it administers at least one small business loan guarantee program and repeated our main analyses separately with respondents whose agencies do or do not administer these kinds of programs; the results from these analyses, presented in Tables S15 and S16, respectively, yield substantively similar results.

⁹ We also randomize the partisan affiliation of the state legislators requesting the audit, which we use to evaluate our pre-registered hypotheses H4a-H6b. Please see the Supplemental Information for more details about these hypotheses and the corresponding analyses.

¹⁰ Nonetheless, the prospect of an audit may prompt respondents to be more sensitive to administrative errors and place emphasis on limiting overpayments (Bagley 2019; Kahneman and Tversky 1992; Krause and Hong 2024; Moynihan 2025). However, even if the mere prospect of an audit has this effect, this heightened risk aversion would manifest across all of our treatment conditions, such that any differences we observe across conditions would be attributable only to our stimuli that activate concerns about fraud and accessibility.

ineligible to participate, and that state legislators requested the audit in response to the investigative reports.¹¹ Finally, in our accessibility condition, we again tell respondents that a local news station recently aired investigative reports about SBDP, but that in these reports 20% of businesses who applied for loans were rejected because the program erroneously deemed them ineligible, again prompting an audit at the request of state legislators.

After reading their assigned vignette, each respondent is then presented with five potentially burdensome requirements for SBDP's eligibility verification system and asked whether they would recommend increasing, decreasing, or making no change to the level of administrative burden associated with each requirement. The five requirements, which are drawn from common features of small business loan guarantee programs at different levels of government across the United States, are: documentation to verify income/revenue; inventories of assets and liabilities; business plan that justifies need for the loan; references from the applicants' suppliers; and minimum applicant credit score.¹² In our analysis, we recode

¹¹ While our vignette does not make explicit why businesses may have been ineligible, loan guarantee programs typically establish clear criteria for the kinds of businesses that can participate and permitted expenses, and the outcome questions which are presented as mechanisms to verify eligibility give respondents context for why businesses may have been ineligible (e.g., the business may have too much income to be considered "small," the type of business or expense for which the loan is issued is prohibited).

¹² For example, the websites for the small business loan guarantee programs in Connecticut and Vermont tell applicants they will need to provide documentation to verify income/revenue, inventories of assets and liabilities, and business plans that justify the need for the loan (*Connecticut Small Business Boost Fund*, <https://ctsmallbusinessboostfund.org/>; "Vermont Small Business Loan Program," *Vermont Economic Development Corporation*, <https://www.veda.org/financing-options/vermont-commercial-financing/small-business-loan-program/>). Additionally the rules governing the US Department of Agriculture's Rural Development loan guarantee programs require that applicants' credit ratings and contractual obligations with suppliers be considered when determining whether to approve applications (7 CFR § 4279.131 (2026), <https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-7/subtitle-B/chapter-XLII/part-4279/subpart-B/section-4279.131>), and the Small Business Administration's 7(a) loan guarantee program requires a minimum credit score for all loans based on the lower end of the risk profile of its current portfolio ("Small Business Administration 7(a) Loan Guaranty Program." *Congressional Research Service*, June 30, 2022, <https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/R41146>). While we designed these five requirements to fit our specific policy context—government-backed small business loan guarantees—they reflect survey designs used in other recent studies to measure support for burdens. For instance, Stenderup and Pedersen (2025) ask respondents whether they support reforms that increase "formal documentation requirements" to measure support for burdens, and Pedersen et al. (2024) include in their survey measure of burdens incurred by Danish businesses contracting with the government items such as "expenses for writing and submitting bids" and "documenting eligibility and track record."

responses for each of the five requirements as three-point ordinal variables, where -1 indicates reducing the burden, 1 indicates increasing the burden, and 0 indicates recommending no change to the burden. While many of the requirements we include may seem like class compliance costs, income verification is commonly associated with significant psychological costs. Therefore, while we exclude learning costs, we do capture compliance and psychological costs.¹³ As we pre-registered, we also construct a composite burden scale representing each respondent's preferences for altering burdens across all five of the application requirements; to do so, we sum the numerical values associated with their choices for each requirement and normalize the resulting sums to range between -1 and 1.¹⁴ Consequently, each 0.2-unit shift on this scale corresponds with a change in the level of one of the five application requirements presented.

Results

In Figure 2, we present respondents' support for increasing the level of burden for the requirements presented in the vignette across our control (squares), accessibility (circles), and fraud (triangles) conditions, and how the degree of support in our treatment conditions differs from that in the control condition. Starting with the top two panes, on the left we display the net percentage of respondents in each condition that support increasing the level of burden for each of the five application requirements, and on the right we assess how the degree of support among respondents in the treatment conditions differs from control condition respondents.¹⁵ Because of

¹³ Credit scores are a common component of small business loan guarantee approval processes, but may not fit neatly into existing administrative burden frameworks; while submitting to a credit check can be construed as a psychological cost, some might consider a credit score as an objective data point rather than a burden. Because of this potential concern, we repeat our analysis in Table S17 excluding the credit score item from our scale; the results of this analysis are substantively similar to those presented in Figure 2.

¹⁴ The five items in our composite scale have a standardized Cronbach's α of 0.71, which indicates high internal consistency.

¹⁵ Because our Hypotheses 1-3 invoke 18 hypothesis tests (five application requirements and the composite scale for each of our treatment conditions compared to the control condition, as well as comparing the magnitudes of the fraud and accessibility effects for the same six outcomes), we pre-registered that we would account for our statistical

our trichotomous coding of respondents’ preferences for increasing, decreasing, or maintaining the level of burden associated with each requirement, these values represent the difference between the percentage of respondents who support increasing the burden level and those who support decreasing the burden level. For instance, the 32% net support for increasing the amount of documentation required to verify an applicant’s inventory among respondents in the control condition indicates that the share of respondents in the control condition who support increasing this level of burden is 32 percentage points higher than the share that supports decreasing it.¹⁶

Across the five application requirements, we observe systematic differences in attitudes towards burdens across our randomly assigned overpayment or underpayment scenarios. In support of Hypothesis 1, we note that for all five requirements the net percentage of support for increasing burdens is distinguishably higher among respondents randomly assigned to the fraud condition relative to respondents in the control condition. For instance, whereas the net support for increasing the amount of documentation required to verify an applicant’s income among control condition respondents is 32%, the net support among those in the fraud condition is more than twice as large at 69%. Again, whereas the net support for increasing the minimum credit rating among control condition respondents is -18%, indicating that more respondents would prefer to *lower* the minimum credit rating, the net support for increasing the minimum credit rating among fraud condition respondents is 2%. Together, across all five of the application requirements, we find support for Hypothesis 1; bureaucrats are more likely to support increasing

tests for multiple comparisons. We do so by utilizing Bonferroni-corrected significance thresholds; given our 18 hypothesis tests, our p -value threshold is $p = \frac{0.05}{18} \approx 0.0028$.

¹⁶ The fact that even respondents in the control condition prefer tightening eligibility requirements for four of our five outcome measures may reflect heightened sensitivity to administrative errors in the face of an audit (cf. Footnote 11). However, the presence of an audit exists in all of our treatment conditions, such that the relative differences in support for tightening or loosening requirements across our conditions is attributable to the information about fraud or accessibility invoked by our treatments.

application burdens when their programs are flagged for an overpayment scandal that results in an audit than a standard recurring audit.

Focusing on the results corresponding with the accessibility condition, we also find support for Hypothesis 2, though our treatment effects are distinguishable from zero for only two of the five requirements (Credit Rating and Business Plan). For instance, while the net support for increasing the level of detail required in applicants' business plans is 48% in the control condition, net support for increasing this burden is only 39% among respondents in the accessibility condition—a decrease of approximately 10 percentage points.

Moving to the bottom two panes, we present the level of support for our composite burden scale across treatment conditions on the right and the difference between the level of support among respondents in the control condition with those in each of our treatment conditions on the right. Since each 0.2-unit increment on this scale is associated with increasing or decreasing the level of burden associated with one of the five requirements, our results indicate that while respondents in the control and accessibility conditions support increasing the level of burden for roughly one of the five requirements (0.22 and 0.17, respectively), those in

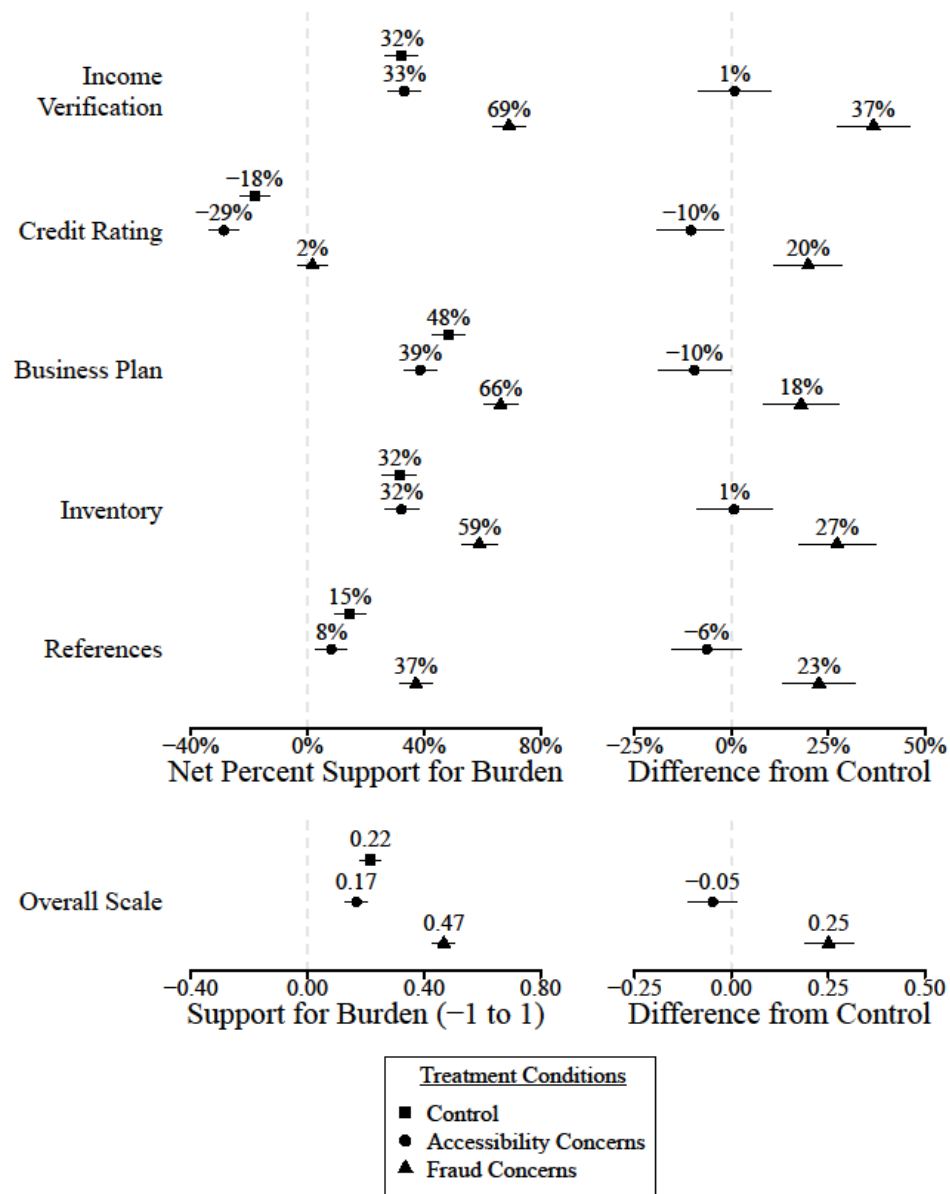


Figure 2. Marginal Effects of Fraud and Access Treatments on the Adoption of Burden.

Points in the left panes reflect the net support for each application requirement (top) and the composite support for all five requirements (bottom) for respondents in the control (square), accessibility (circle), and fraud (triangle) conditions, and lines represent conventional 95% confidence intervals. Points in the right panes represent the differences between the level of support for each requirement (top) or composite support for all five requirements (bottom) among respondents in the control condition and the accessibility (circle) and fraud (triangle) conditions, and lines represent Bonferonni-corrected 95% confidence intervals (see Footnote 16). Any discrepancies between differences in the left pane and corresponding levels of support in the right pane are due to rounding.

the fraud condition support increasing the level of burden for more than two of the five

requirements (0.47). Consistent with our results in the top panes, the level of support associated

with the fraud condition is distinguishably higher than that for the control condition (a difference of 0.25), lending further support to Hypotheses 1. However, the substantively small effect associated with the accessibility condition (-0.05) falls short of statistical distinguishability, thus yielding no further support for Hypothesis 2.

We can also use the estimates in Figure 2 to test Hypothesis 3, in which we expected that the magnitude of the effects associated with the fraud condition would be distinguishably larger than those associated with the accessibility condition; that is to say, information about fraud associated with SBDP prompts respondents to increase burdens more than information about accessibility concerns associated with SBDP prompts them to decrease burdens. To evaluate this hypothesis, we conduct generalized linear hypothesis tests for the regression models associated with each of the six outcome variables where the null hypothesis is that the magnitude of the coefficient associated with the fraud treatment is equal to that of the coefficient associated with the accessibility treatment. In four of the six cases—Income Verification, Inventory, References, and the composite scale—we reject the null hypothesis, as the magnitudes of the fraud treatment are distinguishably larger than those of the accessibility treatment. For instance, for the income verification outcome, the effect of fraud on prompting respondents to increase the amount of documentation required from applicants is 37 times larger than the effect of accessibility concerns on respondents' choices. This finding aligns with our theoretical expectations, revealing the power of fraud concerns in predicting the burden tolerance of bureaucrats.

Finally, we also note the presence of significant variation across the application components in terms of the overall support for increasing requirements, highlighting that not all burdens are equal in the eyes of bureaucrats. For instance, while even respondents in the control and accessibility conditions are supportive of increasing income verification, bureaucrats are not

supportive of increasing credit rating requirements. This suggests that any audit (regardless of the reasoning) may result in increased verification requirements such as income verification, business plans, and inventory, perhaps because application components are considered necessary while others are considered unnecessary and/or biased. These results are theoretically in line with research showing policy domain is not an important predictor of burden tolerance (Campbell and Ahn 2023) but that support for specific strategies varies (Haeder and Moynihan 2024). This has significant implications for burden reduction efforts, suggesting that burden reduction may be more possible on some application elements than others.

Discussion

Our findings have important implications for theory and practice. Burden tolerance studies have focused on factors such as ideology, racial attitudes, and demographic and background characteristics, which may be effective at predicting the burden tolerance of the public but may miss important factors that shape bureaucrats' burden tolerance. Our study highlights an important factor—fire alarms over administrative errors that result in improper payments—that has been understudied but is practically essential for understanding the level of administrative burden in public programs.

Our study makes multiple contributions to current literature. First, we make an important theoretical contribution by integrating the literature on blame avoidance and reputation management with the administrative burden literature. Prior work on blame avoidance has documented how public officials strategically manage information, shift responsibility, and adjust policy positions to deflect criticism and protect their organizational reputations in the wake of negative media attention. Separately, the administrative burden literature has theorized that burdens are adopted as tools of “hidden politics” used by policymakers and bureaucrats to

restrict access to public programs without openly reducing funding or eligibility (Herd & Moynihan, 2018; Moynihan & Herd, 2023). Our study brings these two literatures into direct conversation, demonstrating that bureaucrats perceive the manipulation of administrative burdens as a tool for responding to negative media coverage of administrative errors. In this sense, administrative burden adoption is not only a political instrument wielded from above — it is also a reputational management strategy deployed from within agencies by bureaucrats seeking to deflect scrutiny from political principals and the public. Our findings thus suggest that administrative burden adoption functions as a form of blame avoidance, a connection that has been theorized but not empirically tested in prior work. This integration advances our understanding of the organizational and reputational motivations behind burden adoption for bureaucrats.

Second, we draw from theory on proceduralism to highlight the unique context of bureaucratic agencies that may drive bureaucrats to be more sensitive to fire alarms over overpayments than fire alarms regarding underpayments. By integrating theories of proceduralism, we highlight the tendency of bureaucrats to focus on rules, constraints, and processes to the point that they degrade their own capacity to perform the primary goals the public has assigned them (Moynihan, 2025). This creates an organizational environment in which the asymmetric institutional treatment of overpayments and underpayments becomes systematized. Bureaucrats operating within this environment internalize a set of priorities in which fraud prevention is rendered visible, urgent, and actionable, while access failures are rendered diffuse, attributable to others, and organizationally tolerable. Our findings suggest that proceduralism shapes how bureaucrats respond when programs come under public scrutiny.

This has important theoretical implications for the administrative burden literature. Prior work, drawing primarily on Heinrich's (2016) bureaucratic encounter framework, has tended to treat the citizen-state interface — cell 2 encounters — as the primary site where burden is generated and experienced. Our study draws attention to the intra-organizational dynamics of cell 1, where the organizational culture of proceduralism, institutionalized penalties for wasteful spending, and the asymmetric political salience of fraud shape the burden tolerance of SLBs before they ever encounter a citizen. In this sense, proceduralism functions as a kind of background condition that amplifies the effect of overpayment fire alarms and dampens the effect of underpayment fire alarms, producing the asymmetric pattern of results we observe. Together, our integration of proceduralism into the administrative burden framework offers additional insight into the organizational context that shapes the adoption and intensification of burdens.

Another theoretical implication of our study is that not all application components (potential burdens) are considered equal in the eyes of state bureaucrats in the U.S., though the general impulse is to increase burdens on average (Haeder and Moynihan 2024). Our study provides evidence that bureaucrats consider income verification, business plans, and inventory key components of application processes that they would consider supplementing even when accessibility concerns arise. On the other hand, increasing credit rating requirements was universally opposed by our respondents, though the magnitude did vary across our randomly assigned conditions. Together, our findings suggest that researchers should invest in measuring burden tolerance across different application components to reveal the areas in which burden reduction efforts may be considered more “legitimate” and/or politically feasible.

One of the normative implications of our findings is that administrative burdens may be adopted because of administrative errors, which may shift burdens from the state onto the public even when members of the public have done nothing wrong. Shifting burdens onto the public may also be considered a form of coping Tummers and colleagues (2015) call “moving away from clients” often in response to large workloads (Bell & Meyer, 2023). Thus, fraud concerns may exacerbate these behaviors, and one practical organizational implication of this intersection is that reducing workloads may reduce ‘moving away’ behaviors in contexts with high fraud concerns. This has important normative impacts for public management literature on the balance between fraud and access to public services. Often, fraud is framed as individuals attempting to circumvent eligibility requirements and steal money or benefits that they are not entitled to. However, overpayments to clients are also the fault of flawed government systems and processes (Pahlka, 2023; Peeters & Widlak, 2023; Priergaard, 2024; Rank et al., 2021; Widlak & Peeters, 2020; Young et al., 2023). Therefore, bureaucrats may be penalizing clients for the flaws of antiquated government systems, which increases the time tax on both clients and government. In fact, a recent case in Arizona sheds light on this possibility (Hudetz 2025). Carmen Heredia, former director of the Arizona Health Care Cost Containment System, the state’s Medicaid agency, was forced to resign after her actions intended to address fraudulent billing practices. The state suspended all payments to over 300 businesses with allegedly fraudulent billing practices to hold these entities accountable. In so doing, Medicaid recipients lost coverage to vital benefits with over 500 people becoming homeless and over forty indigenous people dying. Therefore, Heredia’s actions penalized clients for the flaws of corporate billing practices, and that loss of access to vital care led to controversy surrounding her appointment and eventual resignation. This case is just one example of the incredibly important practical balance that

bureaucrats must strike between program integrity and client access, which we hope more scholars will weigh in on in future research.

Before we conclude, we acknowledge that our work is subject to some key limitations. First, as with any survey experiment, external validity is an important consideration. For instance, we study burden tolerance of bureaucrats in response to fire alarms in small business development programs, which are comparatively less politicized than welfare programs. These programs also involve substantially different socially constructed target populations for Republicans and Democrats (Bell, 2021). It is possible that the results would diverge for other programs with more politically contentious programs and for programs that have less powerful target populations who may be socially constructed negatively (“undeserving”) (Nicholson-Crotty et al., 2021). The specifics of such programs also vary widely across different states and localities. We encourage future research to investigate the extent to which our results extend to other policy areas and program specifics.

We also encourage future research to incorporate designs that allow for respondents, bureaucrats in particular, to make tradeoffs between under- and overpayments. Our study provides one step in the direction of understanding bureaucratic responses to either condition but cannot examine how individual bureaucrats might weigh one kind of payment over the other. Along this line of research lies the topic of bureaucratic coping, how individuals respond to and process the psychological stresses of their work (Tummers 2017). While we focus on examining administrative burden behaviors as a result of organizational costs and procedures, future research may consider the individual psychological costs of administrative burden and workload on bureaucratic behavior via the lens of coping. Important external validity concern may arise from our survey, which has a low response rate and covers state bureaucrats in 9 U.S. states but

does not include bureaucrats in other states or in other countries. We encourage future research to test the bounds of our findings in new contexts. However, we strategically chose the 9 states included for their ability to represent the US overall, across various dimensions, so we expect this limitation to be relatively minor.

Conclusion

Public management scholars have dedicated substantial attention to the effects of administrative burden, but less work has examined the causes of administrative burdens (Halling & Baekgaard, 2023). While existing literature highlights public opinion and policymakers' opinions on the imposition of burden (e.g., Aarøe et al., 2021; Baekgaard et al., 2020; Haeder & Moynihan, 2024; Tiggelaar and George 2025), bureaucrats have been understudied (Bell & Smith, 2022; Heinrich et al., 2022). We extend existing work by revealing a novel determinant, external 'fire alarms' about administrative errors, of the burden tolerance of bureaucrats in the United States. To do so, we use a large survey sample drawn from a complete inventory of state bureaucrats in 9 U.S. states and a vignette experimental design.

While previous burden tolerance literature emphasizes the importance of demographic characteristics, political beliefs, and organizational capacity in predicting support for the adoption of administrative burdens, we focus on a factor that we argue is especially important for bureaucrats: fire alarms over administrative errors resulting in improper payments (overpayments or underpayments). We hypothesize that fire alarms over administrative errors resulting in improper payments will meaningfully shift how bureaucrats perceive administrative burdens (specifically application requirements), as bureaucrats attempt to mitigate any negative impacts on organizational reputation and perceptions of programmatic integrity. Our work departs from prior literature by arguing that fire alarms over administrative errors resulting in overpayments

(fraud) will be even more powerful than fire alarms regarding underpayments (access). Our theoretical framework first highlights the unique context in which bureaucrats operate that privileges concerns about fraud over access due to proceduralism, negativity bias, and overcompliance (Bagley, 2019; James et al., 2020; Moynihan, 2025). Second, we highlight the importance of the pervasive gendered and racialized policy image of fraudsters that drives policy preferences in the U.S. and reduces support for government programs (e.g., Gilens, 2009; Hancock, 2004).

Using a survey experiment about state small business development programs, we first find that concerns about fraud increase support for implementing additional application requirements while concerns about access slightly reduced support for adopting additional application requirements. These findings have significant implications for burden reduction initiatives across the US and elsewhere, demonstrating the importance of fire alarms over administrative errors in the adoption of administrative burdens.

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Supplemental Information

Section A: Preregistration

We preregistered our experimental design through the Open Science Framework on May 22, 2024 (https://osf.io/epb2g?view_only=b356267aecfe4a4983f6c9721113e818). As we analyzed our survey responses, we made two deviations from our preregistered design concerning which potential respondents in the sampling frame we solicited to participate in the survey and the addition of an exploratory analysis which we include in the main paper. We detail the former deviation here in detail and provide an explanation of how our exploratory analysis arose in SI Section C.2. Additionally, we also here clarify an imprecise component of our preregistered design and how we implemented it in our analysis.

First, in our preregistration, we planned to randomly sample 25% of the email addresses we obtained from state employee directories. We chose this approach to balance both power considerations for all of the modules on the survey while not overburdening public employees.¹⁷ The size of our random sample anticipated a response rate of between 5% and 10%, as reported in recent studies utilizing survey experiments with other elite populations (e.g., Furnas and LaPira 2024; Miller 2022), which would have yielded us approximately 2,600 to 5,200. However, 24 hours after distributing email invitations to the random sample, we observed a response rate of lower than 1%, which prompted concern that we would not obtain enough responses to conduct sufficiently powered analyses.¹⁸ Accordingly, we decided to send email invitations to all state government employees for which we collected email addresses. While the overall response rate of 1.1%, which yielded 2,476 respondents, is lower than expected, the total number of respondents is close to the lower bound of our expectation (2,600), which was calculated in part to ensure sufficient power for our analysis; thus, despite the lower response rate, we obtained enough respondents to assess our main hypotheses as planned.

¹⁷ Starting with the initial sample of 253,344 emails across the nine states, we considered two factors that would inform our expected response rate: 1) the expected turnover of state employees between the time the emails were collected in 2023 and the survey was fielded in 2024 and 2) observed response rates in other recent samples of political elites. First, based on reported turnover rates of states in our sample, we expected approximately 16% of employees in our sample to no longer be employed by their state rendering their email address invalid. Second, examining recent survey experiments of political elites, such as congressional staff and federal lobbyists, we anticipated a response rate of between 5% and 10% (e.g., Furnas and LaPira 2024; Miller 2022). Given these factors, we expected to collect approximately 2,600 to 5,200 responses.

¹⁸ While it is difficult to understand systematic reasons for non-response, anecdotally we believe state government employees are not as responsive as other recently studied elite populations because they have been trained to be cautious when opening and interacting with emails sent from unfamiliar sources. Many potential respondents emailed the author who facilitated survey distribution asking for confirmation and/or evidence that the survey invitation was legitimate, and officials from the information technology (IT) offices of several state agencies called the author to assess whether the emails were associated with a cybersecurity risk. Additionally, several potential respondents informed the author that the policies set forth by their IT offices prevented them from participating, and others indicated that their IT offices send similar messages to “test” the employees’ compliance with agency policies. Separately, several potential respondents also told the author that their agency barred employees from completing outside surveys or participating in academic research unless the activities were pre-approved by the agency head.

Second, our preregistration document indicated that “multiple comparisons corrections will be made as appropriate” but we did not explicitly state how those multiple comparisons corrections would be implemented in the analysis. Because of this imprecision, we later chose to implement Bonferroni corrections because they are the most conservative type of multiple comparison correction, thus biasing against our rejecting the null hypothesis across tests. To determine the appropriate Bonferroni correction for the analyses we present in the main paper, we determined how many unique null hypothesis significance tests in each set of analyses corresponded with Hypotheses 1-3. For the analyses associated with Figure 2, which tests Hypotheses 1-3 for the full sample, we identified 18 hypothesis tests—six comparisons between the control condition and the accessibility condition (one for each of the five application requirements and the composite scale), six comparisons between the control condition and the fraud condition, and six comparisons between the accessibility condition and fraud condition. Thus, the p -value threshold for these tests is $p = \frac{0.05}{18} \approx 0.0028$.

Section B: Survey Protocol

Section B.1: Sampling Procedure

The substantive questions posed by our theory and our research design require a sample of bureaucrats—individuals with experience with designing and administering programs that provide benefits to the public and who are attentive to concerns about administrative errors. Because many US states provide contact information for their bureaucrats publicly, we set about collecting this information for state-level bureaucrats from states that demonstrate variation on important state-level characteristics such as geographic location, resident demographics, and partisanship. State-level bureaucrats in the United States are fitting respondents for our study because, given the structure of federalism in the United States, many bureaucrats at every level of government (federal, state, and local) interact directly with the public and play a role in designing and implementing programs.¹⁹

We started this process in late 2021 by surveying the employee directories of all fifty states to determine which states post the email addresses of its employees publicly. At that time, 25 states provided such information. From those 25 states, we selected a subset of states where it was most feasible to collect the email addresses given the formatting of each state’s directory and such that the subset demonstrated variation on important state-level characteristics. The nine states chosen given these considerations were: Connecticut, Florida, Illinois, Indiana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, North Carolina, Oregon, and Vermont. These states demonstrate substantial variation across important state-level characteristics that could conceivably inform bureaucrats’ perceptions of administrative burdens and how they respond to allegations of fraud and accessibility concerns. For instance, to the extent that respondents may be influenced by region of the country, state size, or the population density of the state, our subset of states includes at least one representative of each of the four Census regions—Northeast (Connecticut, New

¹⁹ Among respondents in our sample, 21.1% reported that they “somewhat” or “very frequently” perform tasks concerning policymaking, 71.6% reported that they “somewhat” or “very frequently” perform tasks concerning policy implementation, and 67.0% reported that they “somewhat” or “very frequently” interact directly with members of the public.

Hampshire, and Vermont), Midwest (Indiana, Illinois, Nebraska), West (Oregon), and South (North Carolina and Florida)—and exhibit considerable variation by total population (e.g., while Florida was the 3rd most populous state in the 2020 Census, Vermont was the 49th most populous) and population density (e.g., while Connecticut was the 4th most densely populated state in the 2020 Census, Nebraska was the 43rd most densely populated). Again, to the degree that state government partisanship may influence how respondents think about burdens and respond to allegations of fraud or accessibility concerns, our sample includes states that have had Democratic (Connecticut, Oregon) and Republican (Florida, Nebraska) trifectas (i.e., the same party controls the governorship and the legislature) for many years, as well as states where parties more frequently alternate power (Illinois, New Hampshire, North Carolina, Vermont). Further, as many burdens are racialized (Ray et al. 2023), respondents in states with higher concentrations of racial minorities may hold different levels of burden tolerance and may respond to our treatments differently; thus, we included both states that have high concentrations of White residents (e.g., Vermont’s population was 89.1% White in the 2020 Census) as well as other states with larger proportions of racial and ethnic minorities (e.g., Florida’s population was only 51.5% White in the 2020 Census).

The sampling frame for the survey in which the survey experiment was embedded was all state government employees in the abovementioned nine states whose email addresses were posted publicly in the employee directories of those states. In the first half of 2023, one of the authors and student research assistants collected the emails from the directories of these states and formatted them into comma-separated files.

The total number of unique email addresses collected from these nine states is 252,316. Initial email invitations were sent to all unique email addresses between May 31 and June 3, 2024, and reminder emails were sent to all respondents that had not yet completed the survey on June 11 and June 18, 2024. Response collection ceased at the end of the day on June 26, 2024, at which point 2,476 respondents had provided an answer to at least one of the outcome questions in the experiment. Subtracting the 33,213 emails which were returned as undeliverable, the response rate for this module is approximately 1.1% ($\frac{2,476}{219,103}$).

Section B.2 Vignette and Question Wording

After responding to a pre-treatment question battery, respondents were prompted to imagine working for the department of commerce in a state different than their own and read a short vignette about a program the department administers, the Small Business Development Program (SBDP). In the vignette, all respondents read that the program is undergoing an audit and the respondent’s boss has asked for their advice on how the department might modify the system for verifying applicants’ eligibility for SBDP. In the vignette, two requirements are independently randomized across respondents: 1) the rationale for the audit and 2) the partisanship of the legislators requesting the audit. The wording of the vignette and the different treatments associated with each requirement are provided below.

Section B.2.1 Vignette

Imagine you work for the state Department of Commerce in a state different from the one where you work now. One of your primary responsibilities is to help administer the Small Business Development Program (SBDP), a loan guarantee program that helps small businesses secure loans from local financial institutions.

[AUDIT RATIONALE REQUIREMENT] [LEGISLATOR PARTISANSHIP TREATMENT REQUIREMENT] have requested a comprehensive audit of the program.

Treatment Requirements

- Audit Rationale
 - Per state law, the SBDP must be reauthorized by the state legislature every five years, and this reauthorization process will occur early next year. Ahead of this process
 - One of the largest local news stations recently ran a series of investigative reports about the SBDP and revealed that 20% of the loans SBDP subsidized last year were erroneously granted to small businesses who were ineligible to participate in the program. In light of the revelations
 - One of the largest local news stations recently ran a series of investigative reports about the SBDP and revealed that 20% of the small businesses who applied for loans under SBDP were rejected because the program erroneously deemed them ineligible to participate in the program. In light of the revelations
- Legislator Partisanship
 - several legislators
 - Democratic legislators
 - Republican legislators

Section B.2.2 Question Wording

In the audit process, your boss has asked you to offer recommendations for how the Department of Commerce might modify its system for verifying eligibility for SBDP. For each of the following items, please indicate whether and how you would recommend modifying the system:

- Documentation to verify income/revenue
 - Require more documentation
 - Require less documentation
 - Make no change to the documentation required
- Inventories of assets and liabilities
 - Require more detailed inventories
 - Require less detailed inventories
 - Make no change to the inventory detail required
- Business plan that justifies need for the loan
 - Require more detailed business plans
 - Require less detailed business plans
 - Make no change to the business plan detail required
- References from the applicant's suppliers

- Require more references
- Require fewer references
- Make no change to the number of required references
- Minimum applicant credit score
 - Increase the minimum credit score for eligibility
 - Decrease the minimum credit score for eligibility
 - Make no change to the minimum credit score for eligibility

Section B.3: Respondent Demographic Characteristics

The only systematic information we were able to collect about state government employees in the full sampling frame was their names, email addresses, the states by which they were employed, and the name of the state agency for which they worked. We present information about survey responsiveness by state in Table S1.²⁰

For respondents who participated in our experiment, we collected information on a range of demographic characteristics pre-treatment. We provide information about the characteristics of our sample of respondents in Table S2.

Because we do not have individual-level demographic information for those in our sampling frame who did not complete the survey, we cannot rigorously assess the representativeness of these characteristics among our respondents to those in the full population of bureaucrats in the 9 sampled states. While any differences between the demographic characteristics of our respondents and those in the sampling frame would not impact the internal validity of our experiment, they could impact its external validity if bureaucrats with different demographic characteristics have systematically different attitudes towards administrative burdens when presented with concerns about fraud or accessibility (Coppock 2019). For instance, knowing that many administrative burdens are racialized, such that they are more likely to be experienced by racial and ethnic minority groups (Ray et al. 2023), and that White and Black individuals express different levels of tolerance for burdens depending on the context in which they exist (Bell et al. 2020; Johnson and Kroll 2021), if the racial and ethnic composition of our respondents differs from that of the full population, then our sample average treatment effects may deviate from the population average treatment effects we seek to recover (Coppock 2019).

While we lack individual-level demographic information for those in our sampling frame, most of the states in our sample regularly publish reports about the state government workforce, and some of the information captured about their employees corresponds with pre-treatment demographic questions we posed to our respondents.²¹ Thus, we can use the aggregate statistics from the state reports to assess how well our sample corresponds with that of the population of

²⁰ Because agencies are inconsistently named across states, we are not able to construct a similarly compact representation of response rates across agencies.

²¹ We could not locate any official government reports from Indiana that report demographic characteristics for its employees; for all other states, we used the official report that was issued closest to the time our survey was fielded, with a preference for reports issued prior to our survey when possible.

bureaucrats in each state. However, these comparisons carry with them a few limitations. First, because each state reports somewhat different information about its workers, our points of comparison vary across states; for example, only 6 of the 9 states in our sample report information about the race/ethnicity of its employees. Second, because the way states measure concepts sometimes differs from how we measured those same concepts on our survey, comparisons between demographic characteristics from our survey with those in the state reports may not represent perfect one-to-one mappings; for instance, the bin sizes we used when asking respondents how many years they have worked for the state government differed from those reported by most states in our sample, making direct comparisons difficult. Third, because of our low response rate, our measures of state-level demographic characteristics are likely to be highly variable compared to those reported for the full population of workers in each state (e.g., our measures of the demographic characteristics of state employees in Connecticut are based on only 188 respondents, compared to 11,929 employees in our sampling frame). For these reasons, some level of difference between the demographic characteristics of our respondents compared to those reported by states for their full population of workers should be expected.

In Table S4, we provide comparisons between demographic characteristics of our respondents from each of the states for which we could locate official state reports that provide demographic information about their workers and the demographic information provided in those reports for the full population of workers in those states.²² Overall, we see considerable similarity between the demographic characteristics of our respondents and that of the full population of workers in those states; for instance, gender breakdowns are consistently close to evenly split while also generally reflecting overrepresentation by female workers, and White workers outnumber those from other racial and ethnic groups. However, we also notice a few differences, which require us to consider what implications they might have for our findings.

- Race—in 3 of 6 states that report the racial/ethnic composition of its workers—Connecticut, Florida, and North Carolina—the proportion of black respondents is roughly

²² The official state reports used to make these comparisons are: “Post-Retirement Tsunami: Trends in Representation and Pay Equity in CT State Government,” *Connecticut Office of the State Comptroller*, June 2024, <https://osc.ct.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Post-Retirement-Surge-Representation-and-Pay-Equity-2.pdf>; “State of Florida: Annual Workforce Report, FY 2023-2024,” *Florida Department of Management Services*, August 14, 2025, <https://dms-media.ccplatform.net/content/download/434221/file/2023%202024%20Annual%20Workforce%20Report%208.14.25%20-%20FINAL.pdf>; “Workforce Data Report,” *Illinois Department of Central Management Services*, March 30, 2025, https://cms.illinois.gov/content/dam/soi/en/web/cms/documents/CMS_Personnel_2025%20Workforce%20Report_260203.pdf; “2024 Personnel Almanac,” *Nebraska Department of Administrative Services*, June 2024, <https://govdocs.nebraska.gov/epubs/P2000/B004-2024.pdf>; “Fiscal Year 2024 Annual Report,” *New Hampshire Department of Administrative Services*, https://www.das.nh.gov/hr/documents/AnnualReports/2024_DOP_ANNUAL_REPORT-V1.pdf; “Current State Employee Statistics,” *North Carolina Office of State Human Resources*, April 2024, <https://web.archive.org/web/20240531140609/https://oshr.nc.gov/work-nc/employee-statistics/current-state-employee-statistics>; “Affirmative Action Report,” *Oregon Department of Administrative Services*, March 5, 2025, <https://www.oregon.gov/das/strategy/Documents/affirmative-action-report-2023-2025.pdf>; “Workforce Report: Fiscal Year 2024,” *Vermont Department of Human Resources*, January 13, 2025, <https://legislature.vermont.gov/assets/Legislative-Reports/Workforce-Report-Fiscal-Year-2024.pdf>.

half that as in the full population of government workers in those states, while the proportion of white respondents is higher than in the full population. To the extent that White state workers are more supportive of burdens than Black workers given their greater lived experience with racialized burdens and in some contexts express lower support for burdens (Bell et al. 2024; Johnson and Kroll 2021; Ray et al. 2023), this imbalance may suggest that our estimates overstate state bureaucrats’ support for higher burdens when prompted by concerns about fraud and understate their support for lower burdens when informed about concerns about accessibility; however, because Black state workers make up relatively small proportion of state government workforces overall (e.g., between 20% and 30% in Connecticut, Florida, and North Carolina, and less than 5% in Nebraska, Oregon, and Vermont), this moderating effect, should it exist, is unlikely to considerably attenuate the substantially-sized estimates we recover.

- **Age and Years of Experience in State Government**—In the five states that report information about the age of its workers and the years of experience its workers have in state government—Illinois, Nebraska, New Hampshire, North Carolina, and Vermont—our respondents tend to be older and have more years of experience than those in the full population of workers in those corresponding state governments. That these two measures trend together makes sense because older individuals have had more opportunity to serve longer in state government. While these imbalance means our respondents do not represent the full population of state workers for these characteristics, they are also advantageous for our study as older, longer-tenured government workers are more likely to have experience with administrative burdens and to be in positions where they can influence the levels of burden implemented for programs; thus, these respondents better reflect the types of state workers whose insights we want to examine through our experiment as compared to the full population of state workers.
- **Education**—In the one state that reports information about its workers’ educational attainment—North Carolina—respondents to our survey exhibit more advanced levels of education than do state workers in the full population. As with the above discussion of the imbalances for age and years of experience, this imbalance suggests our respondents may not be representative of state workers along the dimension of educational attainment, but it is also advantageous for our study as state workers with greater educational attainment are more likely to hold higher-level positions where they have experience with influencing the levels of burden implemented for programs. Therefore, these more educated respondents better reflect the types of state workers whose insights we want to examine with our study relative to the full population of state workers.

Table S1: Sampling Frame Response Rates by State

State	# of respondents	# of employees invited to participate	Response rate
Connecticut	188	11,929	1.6%
Florida	424	68,178	0.6%

Illinois	27	1,840	1.5%
Indiana	165	27,168	0.6%
Nebraska	315	12,701	2.5%
New Hampshire	22	8,898	0.2%
North Carolina	520	48,283	1.1%
Oregon	721	36,460	2.0%
Vermont	94	3,645	2.6%
TOTAL	2,476	219,103	1.1%

Table S2: Respondent Demographic Characteristics

	# (%) of respondents
<u>Gender</u>	
Male	1115 (45.0%)
Female	1305 (52.7%)
Something else/Other	27 (1.1%)
Prefer not to say	25 (1.0%)
NA	4 (0.2%)
<u>Age</u>	
18-29	129 (5.2%)
30-49	1091 (44.1%)
50-64	1070 (43.2%)
65 or older	185 (7.5%)
NA	1 (0.0%)
<u>Income</u>	
Less than \$25,000	6 (0.2%)
\$25,000-\$49,999	207 (8.4%)
\$50,000-\$74,999	460 (18.6%)
\$75,000-\$99,999	489 (19.7%)
\$100,000-\$199,999	991 (40.0%)
\$200,000 or more	303 (12.2%)
NA	20 (0.8%)
<u>Education</u>	
Some high school, or less	1 (0.0%)
High school graduate or GED	84 (3.4%)
Some college, no 4-year degree	357 (14.4%)
College graduate	911 (36.8%)
Post-graduate degree	1120 (45.2%)
NA	3 (0.1%)
<u>Race</u>	
American Indian or Alaska Native	17 (0.7%)
American Indian or other Pacific Islander	10 (0.4%)
Asian	62 (2.5%)
Black or African American	217 (8.8%)
Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander	5 (0.2%)
Other	131 (5.3%)
White	2018 (81.5%)

NA	16 (0.6%)
<u>Hispanic</u>	
Yes	164 (6.6%)
No	2277 (92.0%)
Prefer not to say	29 (1.2%)
NA	6 (0.2%)
<u>Party Identification</u>	
Strong Democrat	717 (29.0%)
Not a very strong Democrat	335 (13.5%)
Lean Democrat	296 (12.0%)
Independent	244 (9.9%)
Lean Republican	155 (6.3%)
Not a very strong Republican	210 (8.5%)
Strong Republican	285 (11.5%)
Other/NA	234 (9.5%)
<u>Ideology</u>	
Very liberal	268 (10.8%)
Liberal	603 (24.4%)
Slightly liberal	311 (12.6%)
Moderate	629 (25.4%)
Slightly conservative	194 (7.8%)
Conservative	359 (14.5%)
Very conservative	104 (4.2%)
NA	8 (0.3%)
<u>Years of Experience in State</u>	
<u>Government</u>	
Less than 5 years	589 (23.8%)
5-10 years	703 (28.4%)
11-15 years	306 (12.4%)
16-20 years	285 (11.5%)
More than 20 years	591 (23.9%)
NA	2 (0.1%)
<u>Job Selection Method</u>	
Appointed by elected official	85 (3.4%)
Hired/promoted through civil service system	2016 (81.4%)
Other	372 (15.0%)
NA	3 (0.1%)
<u>Burden Tolerance (Baekgaard et al. 2024)</u>	
1.00-1.75	1182 (47.8%)
2.00-2.75	781 (31.6%)
3.00-3.75	442 (17.9%)
4.00-5.00	67 (2.7%)
NA	0 (0.0%)
<u>How Frequently Respondent Engages in Policymaking Tasks</u>	
Never	1011 (40.8%)
Not very frequently	845 (34.1%)
Somewhat Frequently	435 (17.6%)
Very Frequently	185 (7.5%)

NA	0 (0.0%)
<u>How Frequently Respondent Engages in Implementation Tasks</u>	
Never	243 (9.8%)
Not very frequently	209 (8.4%)
Somewhat frequently	584 (23.6%)
Very frequently	1435 (48.0%)
NA	5 (0.2%)
<u>How Frequently Respondent Interacts Directly with Members of the Public</u>	
Never	204 (8.2%)
Not very frequently	612 (24.7%)
Somewhat frequently	574 (23.2%)
Very frequently	1084 (43.8%)
NA	2 (0.1%)

Table S3: Respondent Demographic Characteristics by Treatment Condition and Randomization Checks

	# (%) of respondents in...			
	Control	Accessibility	Fraud	χ test statistic (p-value)
<u>State of Employment</u>				
Connecticut	59 (31.4%)	54 (28.7%)	75 (30.9%)	23.60 (0.10)
Florida	157 (37.0%)	138 (32.5%)	129 (30.4%)	
Illinois	12 (44.4%)	7 (25.9%)	8 (29.6%)	
Indiana	65 (39.4%)	57 (34.5%)	43 (26.1%)	
Nebraska	107 (34.0%)	97 (30.8%)	111 (35.2%)	
New Hampshire	12 (54.5%)	5 (22.7%)	5 (22.7%)	
North Carolina	165 (31.7%)	188 (36.2%)	167 (32.1%)	
Oregon	240 (33.3%)	264 (36.6%)	217 (30.1%)	
Vermont	30 (31.9%)	38 (40.4%)	26 (27.7%)	
<u>Gender</u>				
Male	383 (34.3%)	391 (35.1%)	341 (30.6%)	7.06 (0.53)
Female	442 (33.9%)	438 (33.6%)	425 (32.6%)	
Something else/Other	11 (40.7%)	7 (25.9%)	9 (33.3%)	
Prefer not to say	11 (44.0%)	10 (40.0%)	4 (16.0%)	
NA	0 (0.0%)	2 (50.0%)	2 (50.0%)	
<u>Age</u>				
18-29	44 (34.1%)	37 (28.7%)	48 (37.2%)	6.20 (0.63)
30-49	374 (34.3%)	373 (34.2%)	344 (31.5%)	
50-64	361 (33.7%)	372 (34.8%)	337 (31.5%)	
65 or older	361 (33.7%)	372 (34.8%)	337 (31.5%)	
NA	0 (0.0%)	0 (0.0%)	1 (100.0%)	
<u>Income</u>				
Less than \$25,000	5 (83.3%)	0 (0.0%)	1 (16.7%)	16.19 (0.18)
\$25,000-\$49,999	70 (33.8%)	67 (32.4%)	70 (33.8%)	
\$50,000-\$74,999	163 (35.4%)	167 (36.3%)	130 (28.3%)	

\$75,000-\$99,999	181 (37.0%)	149 (30.5%)	159 (32.5%)	
\$100,000-\$199,999	319 (32.2%)	350 (35.3%)	322 (32.5%)	
\$200,000 or more	100 (33.0%)	109 (36.0%)	94 (31.0%)	
NA	9 (45.0%)	6 (30.0%)	5 (25.0%)	
<u>Education</u>				
Some high school, or less	0 (0.0%)	0 (0.0%)	1 (100.0%)	9.06 (0.53)
High school graduate or GED	32 (38.1%)	23 (27.4%)	29 (34.5%)	
Some college, no 4-year degree	111 (31.1%)	120 (33.6%)	126 (35.3%)	
College graduate	316 (34.7%)	317 (34.8%)	278 (30.5%)	
Post-graduate degree	387 (34.6%)	386 (34.5%)	347 (31.0%)	
NA	1 (33.3%)	2 (66.7%)	0 (0.0%)	
<u>Race</u>				
American Indian or Alaska Native	5 (29.4%)	6 (35.3%)	6 (35.5%)	11.83 (0.62)
American Indian or other Pacific Islander	2 (20.0%)	4 (40.0%)	4 (40.0%)	
Asian	19 (30.6%)	18 (29.0%)	25 (40.3%)	
Black or African American	73 (33.6%)	82 (37.8%)	62 (28.6%)	
Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander	4 (80.0%)	0 (0.0%)	1 (20.0%)	
Other	43 (32.8%)	49 (37.4%)	39 (29.8%)	
White	695 (34.4%)	682 (33.8%)	641 (29.8%)	
NA	6 (37.5%)	7 (43.8%)	3 (18.8%)	
<u>Hispanic</u>				
Yes	57 (34.8%)	53 (32.3%)	54 (32.9%)	3.23 (0.78)
No	778 (34.2%)	782 (34.3%)	717 (31.5%)	
Prefer not to say	9 (31.0%)	10 (34.5%)	10 (34.5%)	
NA	3 (50.0%)	3 (50.0%)	0 (0.0%)	
<u>Party Identification</u>				
Strong Democrat	243 (33.9%)	239 (33.3%)	235 (32.8%)	15.02 (0.24)
Not a very strong Democrat	112 (33.4%)	111 (33.1%)	112 (33.4%)	
Lean Democrat	109 (36.8%)	92 (31.1%)	95 (32.1%)	
Independent	69 (28.3%)	89 (36.5%)	86 (35.2%)	
Lean Republican	51 (32.9%)	56 (36.1%)	48 (31.0%)	
Not a very strong Republican	76 (36.2%)	85 (40.5%)	49 (23.3%)	
Strong Republican	93 (32.6%)	91 (31.9%)	101 (35.4%)	
Other/NA	94 (40.2%)	85 (36.3%)	55 (23.5%)	
<u>Ideology</u>				
Very liberal	93 (34.7%)	87 (32.5%)	88 (32.8%)	2.74 (1.00)
Liberal	211 (35.0%)	204 (33.8%)	188 (31.2%)	
Slightly liberal	107 (34.4%)	106 (34.1%)	98 (31.5%)	
Moderate	206 (32.8%)	220 (35.0%)	203 (32.3%)	
Slightly conservative	63 (32.5%)	71 (36.6%)	60 (30.9%)	
Conservative	128 (35.7%)	120 (33.4%)	111 (30.9%)	
Very conservative	36 (34.6%)	38 (36.5%)	30 (28.8%)	

NA	3 (37.5%)	2 (25.0%)	3 (37.5%)	
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>				
Less than 5 years	186 (31.6%)	209 (35.5%)	194 (32.9%)	9.66 (0.47)
5-10 years	243 (34.6%)	242 (34.4%)	218 (31.0%)	
11-15 years	111 (36.3%)	99 (32.4%)	96 (31.4%)	
16-20 years	111 (38.9%)	89 (31.2%)	85 (29.8%)	
More than 20 years	196 (33.2%)	207 (35.0%)	188 (31.8%)	
NA	0 (0.0%)	2 (100.0%)	0(0.0%)	
<u>Job Selection Method</u>				
Appointed by elected official	26 (30.6%)	32 (37.6%)	27 (31.8%)	7.80 (0.25)
Hired/promoted through civil service system	682 (33.8%)	689 (34.2%)	645 (32.0%)	
Other	136 (36.6%)	127 (34.1%)	109 (29.3%)	
NA	3 (100.0%)	0 (0.0%)	0 (0.0%)	
<u>Burden Tolerance (Baekgaard et al. 2024)</u>				
1.00-1.75	407 (34.4%)	408 (34.5%)	367 (31.0%)	6.34 (0.61)
2.00-2.75	272 (34.8%)	266 (34.1%)	243 (31.1%)	
3.00-3.75	145 (32.8%)	146 (33.0%)	151 (34.2%)	
4.00-5.00	22 (32.8%)	28 (41.8%)	17 (25.4%)	
NA	1 (25.0%)	0 (0.0%)	3 (75.0%)	
<u>How Frequently Respondent Engages in Policymaking Tasks</u>				
Never	332 (32.8%)	349 (34.5%)	330 (32.6%)	3.67 (0.72)
Not very frequently	288 (34.1%)	291 (34.4%)	266 (31.5%)	
Somewhat Frequently	156 (35.9%)	144 (33.1%)	135 (31.0%)	
Very Frequently	71 (38.4%)	64 (34.6%)	50 (27.0%)	
NA	0 (0.0%)	0 (0.0%)	0 (0.0%)	
<u>How Frequently Respondent Engages in Implementation Tasks</u>				
Never	65 (26.7%)	93 (38.3%)	85 (35.0%)	11.43 (0.18)
Not very frequently	73 (34.9%)	64 (30.6%)	72 (34.4%)	
Somewhat frequently	205 (35.1%)	190 (32.5%)	189 (32.4%)	
Very frequently	503 (35.1%)	500 (34.8%)	432 (30.1%)	
NA	1 (20.0%)	1 (20.0%)	3 (60.0%)	

Table S4: Comparison of Demographic Characteristics of Respondents to Full Population of State-Level Government Workers in Their States

	% of respondents	% of state workers
CONNECTICUT		

<u>Gender</u>		
Female	48.4%	52%
Male	50.0%	48%
Other/NA	1.5%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
Asian, Non-Hispanic	4.2%	4%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	10.6%	20%
Hispanic	13.8%	13%
White, Non-Hispanic	66.5%	63%
Other, Non-Hispanic/NA	4.9%	-
FLORIDA		
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	56.1%	57.9%
Male	42.7%	42%
Other/NA	1.1%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	14.8%	28.3%
Hispanic	11.0%	13.7%
White, Non-Hispanic	67.4%	52.8%
Other, Non-Hispanic/NA	6.8%	5.1%
ILLINOIS		
<u>Age</u>		
Median/Mode	Modal age bin of 50-64	47 years, 4 months
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>		
Median/Mode	Modal respondent has at least 11 years or more	Only reported at agency-level, all but one agency has a median of 7 years and 2 months or more
NEBRASKA		
<u>Age</u>		
18-29	6.3%	17.5%
30-49	43.5%	44.1%
50-64	40.6%	32.7%
65 and over	9.5%	5.7%
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	53.7%	54%
Male	44.1%	46%
Other/NA	2.3%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
Asian, Non-Hispanic	1.3%	2%

Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	4.8%	4%
Hispanic	5.1%	5%
White, Non-Hispanic	83.2%	85%
Other, Non-Hispanic /NA	5.6%	4%

Years of Experience in State
Government

Mean/Mode	Modal respondent has 10 or fewer years of service	Average of 9.5 years
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NEW HAMPSHIRE

Age

18-29	0.0%	10.8%
30-49	63.6%	44.2%
50-64	22.7%	39.3%
65 and over	13.6%	5.6%

Gender

Female	50.0%	54.5%
Male	50.0%	45.5%

Years of Experience in State
Government

Less than 5 years	18.2%	40.6%
5 Years or More	81.8%	59.4%

NORTH CAROLINA

Age

18-29	4.6%	12%
30-49	41.7%	45%
50 and over	53.4%	42%
NA	0.2%	-

Gender

Female	50.8%	53%
Male	47.1%	47%
Other/NA	2.2%	-

Race/Ethnicity

American Indian/Alaskan/Pacific Islander, Non-Hispanic	0.6%	2%
Asian, Non-Hispanic	2.5%	3%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	15.2%	30%
Hispanic	1.8%	4%
White, Non-Hispanic	76.3%	60%
Other, Non-Hispanic /NA	3.6%	2%

Education

Less than high school	0.0%	5%
High school/some college but no four-year degree	15.4%	33%
Four-year college degree	33.1%	28%
Post-graduate degree	51.3%	13%
Other/NA	0.2%	1%

Years of Experience in State

Government

Less than 5 years	19.4%	31%
5 Years or More	80.6%	69%

OREGON

Gender

Female	53.4%	57%
Male	43.1%	43%
Other/NA	3.4%	-

Race/Ethnicity

American Indian, Non-Hispanic	0.9%	2.2%
American Indian or other Pacific Islander, Non-Hispanic	0.4%	0.7%
Asian, Non-Hispanic	2.8%	4.5%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	2.2%	2.7%
Hispanic	7.7%	10.6%
White, Non-Hispanic	82.0%	72.2%
Other, Non-Hispanic/NA	3.4%	7.0%

VERMONT

Gender

Female	50.0%	52.2%
Male	47.9%	47.8%
Other/NA	2.2%	-

Race/Ethnicity

American Indian, Non-Hispanic	0.3%	0.4%
American Indian or other Pacific Islander, Non-Hispanic	0.0%	0.1%
Asian, Non-Hispanic	0.0%	1.3%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	1.1%	1.5%
Hispanic	1.1%	1.8%
White, Non-Hispanic	90.4%	93.7%
Other, Non-Hispanic/NA	6.4%	1.2%

Age

Mean/Mode	Modal respondent in 50-64 years old bin	Mean of 44.9 years old
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Years of Experience in State
Government

Less than 5 years	8.5%	38.3%
5 Years or More	91.5%	61.7%

Values in first column represent proportion of respondents with each demographic characteristic for each state. Values in second column drawn from official state reports on their state government workforce issued close to their fielding of our survey in May-June 2024. Indiana is excluded as we could not locate any official state reports on their state government workforce that provided demographic information. Where our survey and the state reports differed in terms of potential values for each characteristic (e.g., different sized years of experience bins), we collapsed values to make both data sources as comparable as possible.

Section C: Empirical Analysis

In this section, we present additional information about the empirical analyses we present in the main text and discuss the results of the tests associated with additional pre-registered hypotheses that we do not include in the main text.

Section C.1: Tabular Presentation of Results Presented in the Main Paper

Table S5 presents the tabular results of the models which underlie Figure 1 in the main text.

Table S5: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens

	(1) Documentation	(2) Credit Rating	(3) Business Plan	(4) References	(5) Inventories	(6) Burden Scale
Intercept	0.32 * (0.03)	-0.18 * (0.03)	0.48 * (0.03)	0.15 * (0.03)	0.32 * (0.03)	0.22 * (0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	0.01 (0.03)	-0.10 * (0.03)	-0.10 * (0.03)	-0.06 (0.03)	0.01 (0.03)	-0.05 (0.02)
Fraud Concerns	0.37 * (0.03)	0.20 * (0.03)	0.18 * (0.03)	0.23 * (0.03)	0.27 * (0.03)	0.25 * (0.02)
Democratic Legislators	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	-0.00 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)
Republican Legislators	0.05 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.06 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)
Num. obs.	2473	2472	2473	2472	2471	2463

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the Bonferroni-corrected $p < \frac{0.05}{18} \approx 0.0028$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent.

Section C.2: Additional Pre-Registered Hypotheses

In our pre-analysis plan, we pre-registered 9 hypotheses. Hypotheses 1 through 3, which we examine in the main text, were as follows:

1. When a program attracts attention for fraud, bureaucrats are more supportive of administrative burdens
2. When a program attracts attention for poor accessibility, bureaucrats are less supportive of administrative burdens
3. The positive effect of fraud on support for burdens is of larger magnitude than the negative effect of poor accessibility on administrative burdens

We pre-registered 6 additional hypotheses, H4a-H6b, which were as follows:

4. Respondent-legislator copartisanship and fraud:
 - a. When a program attracts attention for fraud from copartisan legislators, bureaucrats are more supportive of administrative burdens than when it attracts attention for fraud from non-copartisan legislators or legislators with indeterminate party identification.
 - b. When a program attracts attention for fraud from copartisan legislators, bureaucrats are less supportive of administrative burdens than when it attracts attention for fraud from non-copartisan legislators or legislators with indeterminate party identification.
5. Respondent-legislator copartisanship for accessibility:
 - a. When a program attracts attention for poor accessibility from copartisan legislators, bureaucrats are less supportive of administrative burdens than when it attracts attention for poor accessibility from non-copartisan legislators or legislators with indeterminate party identification.
 - b. When a program attracts attention for poor accessibility from copartisan legislators, bureaucrats are more supportive of administrative burdens than when it attracts attention for poor accessibility from non-copartisan legislators or legislators with indeterminate party identification.
6. Respondent-legislator copartisanship (party-specific):
 - a. When a program attracts attention for fraud from copartisan Republican legislators, bureaucrats are more supportive of administrative burdens.
 - b. When a program attracts attention for poor accessibility from copartisan Democratic legislators, bureaucrats are less supportive of administrative burdens.

In general, these hypotheses emerged from an expectation that the degree to which our fraud and accessibility treatments influenced respondents' burden preferences would be conditioned by the correspondence between their own partisan affiliation and that of the legislators who initiated the program audit.

- H4a and H5a are analogues of H1 and H2 that build from the assumption that bureaucrats are more responsive to the concerns of principals when those principals share their partisan affiliation or other kinds of preferences and identities because they trust those principals to make decisions that will bring policy closer to their mutually-held preferences (Bertelli and Grose 2009; Lowande 2019). Conversely, H4b and H5b build from the assumption that bureaucrats are more responsive to the concerns of principals when those principals do not share their partisan affiliation or other kinds of preferences

and identities because they fear greater sanctions from those principals for non-compliance.

- Whereas H4a-b and H5a-b are agnostic as to *which* party the respondents are copartisans of, H6a-b leverage the identities of the parties to expect that respondents will react more strongly to copartisan principals when the rationale for the audit promotes the kinds of changes to burden levels that their party prefers (Herd and Moynihan 2018). Specifically, H6a expects that, because Republicans generally support higher levels of burden, in large part to limit fraud, that Republican respondents will support higher levels of burden when Republican legislators request the audit, while H6b expects that, because Democrats generally oppose higher levels of burden and emphasize program accessibility, that Democratic respondents will support lower levels of burdens when Democratic legislators request the audit.

To evaluate H4a-b and H5a-b, we estimate linear regression models that interact our treatment which provides the rationale for the program audit with a trichotomous indicator for whether the respondent is a copartisan of the legislators requesting the audit, a non-copartisan, or whether this correspondence is indeterminate (e.g., a Democrat in the control condition for legislator partisanship). The results for the corresponding models are presented in Table S6. None of the coefficients for the interaction terms are statistically distinguishable, indicating that we find no support for H4a-b or H5a-b.

To evaluate H6a-b, we estimate linear regression models that interact our treatment which provides the rationale for the program audit with a categorical variable that can take on one of the following four values:

1. Indeterminate—there is no clear correspondence between the partisan affiliation of the respondent and the legislators requesting the audit (i.e., the partisan affiliation of the legislators is not disclosed).
2. Copartisan Democrat—the respondent is a Democrat and the legislators requesting the audit are Democrats.
3. Copartisan Republican—the respondent is a Republican and the legislators requesting the audit are Republicans.
4. Noncopartisan—the respondent’s partisan affiliation is different from that of the legislators requesting the audit (e.g., the respondent is a Republican and the legislators are Democrats).

The results for the corresponding models, presented in Table S7, do not provide support for H6a or H6b; in fact, the only two interaction terms that are statistically distinguishable suggest that Republican respondents are *less* supportive of burdens when Republican legislators request an audit following allegations of fraud, which is the opposite of what is expected by H6a.

From a theoretical standpoint, we believe that the null effects associated with our pre-registered hypotheses H4a-H6b can be explained by the nature of the task we asked bureaucrats to complete. Each of the application requirements we asked bureaucrats to evaluate is likely under the complete control of the state agency rather than the legislature. Therefore, bureaucrats may have been less responsive to the partisanship of the legislature than we expected because they

believed each application requirement was a part of policy implementation rather than policy design, which legislators may have more authority to control.

However, in interpreting the interactive effects in the models in Table S7, we found that Democratic respondents who are told that Democratic legislators are requesting the audit after allegations of fraud consistently exhibit higher levels of support for burdens that are often statistically distinguishable from those associated with similarly situated Republican respondents. This unexpected finding led us to conduct an exploratory analysis, which we present in Table S8, that compares the treatment effects of Democratic and Republican respondents without conditioning on the treatment requirement that identifies the partisanship of the legislators requesting the audit; there, we find that Democratic respondents respond more strongly to the fraud treatment than do Republican respondents. While this exploratory analysis was not pre-registered, it emerged as a natural product of our assessment of our other pre-registered hypotheses and produces a novel insight that contrasts with prior work—while Democrats may generally have lower burden tolerance than Republicans (e.g., Bell et al. 2021), concerns about program fraud prompts Democrats to have higher levels of burden tolerance on par with those expressed by Republicans.

Table S6: Copartisanship-Conditional Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens

	(1) Documentation	(2) Credit Rating	(3) Business Plan	(4) References	(5) Inventories	(6) Burden Scale
Intercept	0.30 *	-0.19 *	0.48 *	0.16 *	0.33 *	0.22 *
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Accessibility Concerns	0.05	-0.05	-0.08	-0.07	0.01	-0.03
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Fraud Concerns	0.41 *	0.20 *	0.18 *	0.24 *	0.26 *	0.26 *
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Copartisan Legislators	0.12 *	0.01	0.04	-0.03	-0.01	0.03
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Noncopartisan Legislators	0.08	0.06	0.04	0.00	0.01	0.04
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Accessibility:Copart	-0.04	-0.02	-0.04	0.04	0.08	0.00
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Fraud:Copart	-0.13	0.02	-0.06	0.01	-0.00	-0.03
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Accessibility:Noncopart	-0.12	-0.13	-0.04	-0.02	-0.11	-0.08
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Fraud:Noncopart	-0.06	-0.07	-0.00	-0.10	-0.00	-0.04
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Num. obs.	1996	1995	1996	1994	1995	1988

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Models include only respondents who self-identified as Democrats or Republicans.

Table S7: Democratic and Republican Copartisanship-Conditional Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens

(1) Documentation	(2) Credit Rating	(3) Business Plan	(4) References	(5) Inventories	(6) Burden Scale	
Intercept	0.30 *	-0.19 *	0.48 *	0.16 *	0.33 *	0.22 *
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Accessibility Concerns	0.05	-0.05	-0.08	-0.07	0.01	-0.03
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Fraud Concerns	0.41 *	0.20 *	0.18 *	0.24 *	0.26 *	0.26 *
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Dem Copartisan Legislators	0.06	-0.13 *	-0.02	-0.11	-0.10	-0.06
	(0.07)	(0.06)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.04)
GOP Copartisan Legislators	0.22 *	0.28 *	0.16	0.12	0.16	0.19 *
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.05)
Accessibility:Dem Copart	-0.09	0.03	-0.07	0.04	0.11	0.00
	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.06)
Accessibility:GOP Copart	0.02	-0.15	-0.02	0.01	-0.01	-0.03
	(0.11)	(0.10)	(0.12)	(0.11)	(0.12)	(0.08)
Fraud:Dem Copart	-0.07	0.13	-0.01	0.10	0.11	0.05
	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.06)
Fraud:GOP Copart	-0.23 *	-0.18	-0.16	-0.14	-0.21	-0.18 *
	(0.12)	(0.11)	(0.12)	(0.12)	(0.13)	(0.08)
Accessibility:Noncopart	-0.12	-0.13	-0.04	-0.02	-0.11	-0.08
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Fraud:Noncopart	-0.06	-0.07	-0.00	-0.10	-0.00	-0.04
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Num. obs.	1996	1995	1996	1994	1995	1988

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Models include only respondents who self-identified as Democrats or Republicans.

Table S8: Partisanship-Conditional Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens

	(1) Documentation	(2) Credit Rating	(3) Business Plan	(4) References	(5) Inventories	(6) Burden Scale
Intercept	0.30 *	-0.29 *	0.47 *	0.14 *	0.28 *	0.18 *
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	-0.02	-0.06	-0.11	-0.07	0.03	-0.04
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Fraud Concerns	0.40 *	0.24 *	0.20 *	0.23 *	0.34 *	0.29 *
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Democratic Legislators	0.02	0.01	-0.03	-0.04	-0.01	-0.01
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Republican Legislators	0.04	0.04	0.06	-0.04	0.00	0.02
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
GOP Respondent	0.10	0.39 *	0.09	0.09	0.17	0.17 *
	(0.07)	(0.06)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.04)
Accessibility Concerns: GOP Respondent	0.04	-0.15	0.02	0.00	-0.09	-0.03
	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.05)
Fraud Concerns: GOP Respondent	-0.17	-0.18	-0.13	-0.05	-0.26 *	-0.16 *

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
GOP Respondent	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.05)
Democratic Legislators:	-0.03	-0.10	-0.04	0.01	-0.06	-0.05
GOP Respondent	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.05)
Republican Legislators:	0.08	-0.06	0.00	0.08	0.05	0.03
GOP Respondent	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.05)
Num. obs.	1996	1995	1996	1994	1995	1988

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the Bonferroni-corrected $p < \frac{0.05}{36} \approx 0.0014$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Models include only respondents who self-identified as Democrats or Republicans, where the omitted category is Democratic respondents.

Section C.3: Alternative Model Specifications

Table S9: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Frequently Engage in Policymaking

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.27 *	-0.22 *	0.45 *	0.14 *	0.26 *	0.18 *
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.03)
Accessibility Concerns	-0.00	-0.09	-0.09	-0.08	0.03	-0.04
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Fraud Concerns	0.43 *	0.22 *	0.21 *	0.24 *	0.39 *	0.30 *
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Democratic Legislators	0.02	-0.01	0.02	0.02	-0.02	0.00
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Republican Legislators	0.08	0.07	-0.02	-0.03	0.00	0.02
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Num. obs.	619	617	618	619	619	616

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who indicate that they “somewhat” or “very” frequently engage in policymaking tasks are included in these analyses.

Table S10: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Infrequently Engage in Policymaking

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.34 *	-0.17 *	0.50 *	0.15 *	0.34 *	0.23 *
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	0.01	-0.11 *	-0.10 *	-0.06	-0.00	-0.05 *
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.02)
Fraud Concerns	0.34 *	0.19 *	0.16 *	0.22 *	0.23 *	0.23 *
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.02)
Democratic Legislators	-0.02	-0.02	-0.05	-0.01	-0.02	-0.02
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.02)
Republican Legislators	0.04	0.00	0.08 *	0.00	0.05	0.04
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.02)
Num. obs.	1854	1855	1855	1853	1852	1847

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who indicate that they “not very frequently” or “never” engage in policymaking tasks are included in these analyses.

Table S11: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Frequently Engage in Implementation

	(1) Documentation	(2) Credit Rating	(3) Business Plan	(4) References	(5) Inventories	(6) Burden Scale
Intercept	0.34 * (0.03)	-0.17 * (0.03)	0.50 * (0.03)	0.17 * (0.03)	0.34 * (0.03)	0.23 * (0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	0.01 (0.03)	-0.11 * (0.03)	-0.07 * (0.03)	-0.08 * (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.05 * (0.02)
Fraud Concerns	0.38 * (0.03)	0.19 * (0.03)	0.21 * (0.03)	0.22 * (0.03)	0.27 * (0.04)	0.26 * (0.02)
Democratic Legislators	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.06 (0.04)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.04)	-0.03 (0.02)
Republican Legislators	0.03 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	0.01 (0.02)
Num. obs.	2016	2015	2016	2015	2014	2006

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who indicate that they “somewhat” or “very” frequently engage in implementation tasks are included in these analyses.

Table S12: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Infrequently Engage in Implementation

	(1) Documentation	(2) Credit Rating	(3) Business Plan	(4) References	(5) Inventories	(6) Burden Scale
Intercept	0.27 * (0.07)	-0.24 * (0.07)	0.42 * (0.07)	0.02 (0.07)	0.23 * (0.07)	0.14 * (0.05)
Accessibility Concerns	0.03 (0.08)	-0.06 (0.07)	-0.19 * (0.08)	0.04 (0.08)	0.02 (0.08)	-0.03 (0.06)
Fraud Concerns	0.30 * (0.08)	0.24 * (0.07)	0.07 (0.08)	0.25 * (0.08)	0.28 * (0.08)	0.23 * (0.06)
Democratic Legislators	0.04 (0.08)	-0.02 (0.07)	0.06 (0.08)	0.04 (0.07)	0.06 (0.08)	0.03 (0.05)
Republican Legislators	0.14 (0.08)	0.07 (0.07)	0.15 (0.08)	0.04 (0.08)	0.15 (0.08)	0.11 * (0.05)
Num. obs.	452	452	452	452	452	452

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who indicate that they “not very frequently” or “never” engage in implementation tasks are included in these analyses.

Table S13: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Frequently Interact Directly with Members of the Public

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.35 *	-0.18 *	0.47 *	0.16 *	0.36 *	0.23 *
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	-0.03	-0.10 *	-0.10 *	-0.06	-0.04	-0.06 *
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Fraud Concerns	0.36 *	0.19 *	0.18 *	0.24 *	0.24 *	0.24 *
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Democratic Legislators	-0.04	-0.04	-0.02	-0.02	-0.03	-0.03
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Republican Legislators	0.06	-0.00	0.08 *	-0.01	0.02	0.03
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)
Num. obs.	1656	1656	1656	1654	1654	1648

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the p<0.05 level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who indicate that they “somewhat” or “very” frequently interact directly with members of the public are included in these analyses.

Table S14: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Infrequently Interact Directly with Members of the Public

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.27 *	-0.20 *	0.50 *	0.12 *	0.23 *	0.18 *
	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.03)
Accessibility Concerns	0.09	-0.12 *	-0.09	-0.06	0.10	-0.01
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Fraud Concerns	0.40 *	0.21 *	0.19 *	0.21 *	0.34 *	0.27 *
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Democratic Legislators	0.05	0.05	-0.06	0.02	0.00	0.01
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.04)
Republican Legislators	0.03	0.06	0.02	-0.00	0.07	0.04
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.03)
Num. obs.	815	814	815	816	815	813

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the p<0.05 level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who indicate that they “not very frequently” or “never” interact directly with members of the public are included in these analyses.

Table S15: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Work in Agencies Offering Small Business Loan Guarantee Programs

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.51 *	-0.11	0.74 *	0.04	0.19	0.27 *
	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.11)	(0.12)	(0.11)	(0.06)
Accessibility Concerns	-0.01	-0.05	-0.20	0.09	0.09	-0.02
	(0.10)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.13)	(0.12)	(0.07)
Fraud Concerns	0.38 *	0.11	0.02	0.31 *	0.38 *	0.24 *
	(0.10)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.13)	(0.12)	(0.07)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Democratic Legislators	-0.08 (0.10)	-0.19 (0.12)	-0.04 (0.12)	-0.14 (0.14)	0.07 (0.13)	-0.07 (0.07)
Republican Legislators	-0.05 (0.10)	0.05 (0.11)	-0.07 (0.11)	0.13 (0.13)	0.16 (0.12)	0.04 (0.07)
Num. obs.	156	156	156	156	156	156

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the p<0.05 level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who work in agencies whose websites include information about loan guarantee programs offered for small businesses are included in these analyses.

Table S16: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens Among Respondents Who Work in Agencies Not Offering Small Business Loan Guarantee Programs

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Documentation	Credit Rating	Business Plan	References	Inventories	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.31 * (0.03)	-0.18 * (0.03)	0.47 * (0.03)	0.15 * (0.03)	0.32 * (0.03)	0.21 * (0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	0.01 (0.03)	-0.11 * (0.03)	-0.09 * (0.03)	-0.07 * (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)	-0.05 * (0.02)
Fraud Concerns	0.37 * (0.03)	0.20 * (0.03)	0.19 * (0.03)	0.22 * (0.03)	0.27 * (0.03)	0.25 * (0.02)
Democratic Legislators	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.02)
Republican Legislators	0.05 (0.03)	0.01 (0.03)	0.06 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)
Num. obs.	2317	2316	2317	2316	2315	2307

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the p<0.05 level (two-tailed). The dependent variable for each model is indicated with the column heading; in Models 1-5, the dependent variable is a five-point ordinal variable, and in Model 6 it is the average of the first five dependent variable values for each respondent. Only respondents who work in agencies whose websites do not include information about loan guarantee programs offered for small businesses are included in these analyses.

Table S17: Effect of Fire Alarms over Administrative Error Treatments on Support for Administrative Burdens (Excluding Credit Score Outcome)

	Burden Scale
Intercept	0.32 * (0.02)
Accessibility Concerns	-0.04 (0.02)
Fraud Concerns	0.26 * (0.02)
Democratic Legislators	-0.02 (0.02)
Republican Legislators	0.03 (0.02)
Num. obs.	2468

Model is estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes statistical significance at the Bonferroni-corrected $p < \frac{0.05}{18} \approx 0.0028$ level (two-tailed). The dependent is the average of the four program eligibility elements (excluding minimum credit score) for each respondent.

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